

ROAD TO RELIEF
FOR BURARI **P3**



'WHY STUDENTS FORCED TO LIVE IN
UNSAFE PGS': RAHUL SLAMS GOVT **P5**

LILY BIDS FAREWELL TO TITLE
CHARACTER **P12**



CEO SAYS NOTICES DO NOT MEAN AUTOMATIC DELETION Advani, Jaishankar, Sandhu among Delhi voters served SIR notices

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, September 20

A large-scale verification exercise of Delhi's electoral rolls has flagged 33.13 lakh voters, including senior bureaucrats, constitutional functionaries, politicians and other prominent public figures, after their details could not be matched with the previous intensive revision or showed discrepancies in information submitted in enumeration forms. The Election Commission has said the notices are part of the verification process and do not by themselves mean that a voter's name will be deleted from the rolls.

Among those whose names figure in the notice lists are former deputy prime minister L K Advani, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, former vice-president Jagdeep Dhankhar, Election Commissioner S S Sandhu, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri, Sebi Chairman Tuhin Kanta



KEY POINTS

- » Delhi SIR flags 33.13 lakh voters for verification
- » Draft roll contains 97,53,577 electors
- » Around 47 lakh names excluded from earlier rolls
- » Delhi CM Rekha Gupta's entry gets validated after verification
- » Claims and objections process ends September 30
- » Final electoral roll scheduled for November 4

Pandey, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal and former deputy chief minister Manish Sisodia.

The list also includes Principal Scientific Adviser to the Prime Minister Ajay

Kumar Sood, Health Secretary Punya Salila, Fisheries Secretary Abhilaksh Likhi and his wife Sukriti Likhi, Fertiliser Secretary Rajat Kumar Mishra and Land Resources Secretary Narendra Bhooshan. Former

NITI Aayog vice-chairman Arvind Panagariya, former JNU vice-chancellor and UGC chairman M Jagadesh Kumar, former defence secretary Giridhar Aramane, former environment secretary Leena Nandan, former

animal husbandry secretary Alka Upadhyay, former consumer affairs secretary Rohit Kumar Singh and former CISF director-general Nina Singh are also among those listed.

Other prominent names include former Delhi lieutenant governor Najeeb Jung, former Army chief Upendra Dwivedi, CBI Director Praveen Sood, New Delhi MP Bansuri Swaraj, former Delhi BJP president Virendra Kumar Sachdeva, Rajya Sabha member Kapil Sibal, former Union minister Subramanian Swamy, Delhi minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, historian Romila Thapar, and former BJP IT cell chief Amit Malviya.

The notices largely relate to the inability to map a voter's present record with the electoral roll from the previous SIR conducted in 2002. Some have been generated over specific discrepancies, including mismatches in names or details of parents.

CONTINUED ON P4

Valarivan stars as India opens Asian Games medal account Wins two shooting silvers on day 1

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi/Nagoya, September 20



(From right) Shooters Elavenil Valarivan, Sonam Uttam Maskar and Vidarsa K Vinod with their silver medals after winning the women's 10m Air Rifle team event ANI

CLOSER LOOK

- » Elavenil Valarivan wins individual 10m air rifle silver
- » Valarivan also wins team event silver with teammates
- » India women enter cricket final after Bangladesh rout

Earlier, Valarivan had teamed up with Sonam Uttam Maskar and Games debutant Vidarsa K Vinod to win silver in the women's 10m air rifle team event. Prime Minister Nar-

endra Modi congratulated Valarivan on X, describing her two-medal day as special and also praising the team's performance.

India secured another medal through 36-year-old Suchika Taryal, who reached the women's traditional 60kg MMA semifinals. Taryal defeated Mongolia's Altanchimeg Baigalmaa 2-0 in the quarterfinals to guarantee at least bronze. She took up MMA in 2024 after earlier training in judo and has since won national titles and bronze

CONTINUED ON P4

BMW plunges off Mumbai bridge, 3 killed



MPOST BUREAU
Mumbai, September 20

Three young men were killed and another was critically injured after a speeding BMW crashed through a boundary wall and plunged from Mumbai's Coastal Road into an under-construction parking area early Sunday, police said. The accident took place around 5:20 am near Lotus Jetty, opposite Lala Lajpatrai College, as the black BMW was travelling from Marine Drive towards Haji Ali.

According to officials, the car lost control while speeding, struck the roadside barrier and fell several feet from the elevated road into the L&T parking

CONTINUED ON P4

RAHUL'S INDORE EVENT BJP, Oppn spar over PM Modi mimicry



Rahul Gandhi with comedian Pulkit Mani during the 'Chhatron ki Goonj' event, in Indore PTI

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, September 20

A political row erupted on Sunday after stand-up comedian Pulkit Mani mimicked Prime Minister Narendra Modi during Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' programme in Indore, with BJP leaders accusing the Congress of lowering political standards and opposition leaders defending the performance as part of

democratic criticism. The skit, performed during Saturday's event in Madhya Pradesh and later shared by the Congress on X, featured Mani approaching Gandhi, laughing and hugging him. "My friend. How are you?" Mani said. Gandhi replied, "I'm fine; how are you, Modi ji?" Mani responded, "Great harassment" and repeatedly used the phrase "my friend". Gandhi then said, "Very nice

CONTINUED ON P4

Iran sets seven conditions for resuming talks with the US

Warns Trump of
'decisive war'

AGENCIES
Doha, September 20

Iran has conveyed seven conditions to the United States through Qatar for restarting negotiations aimed at ending the ongoing war, while warning that Tehran is prepared for a "decisive war" if Washington rejects its demands, Iranian official Mohsen Rezaei said.

Rezaei, secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council, told Al Jazeera that Qatar had passed Tehran's conditions to Washington and that Iran was awaiting US President Donald Trump's response. He publicly outlined three of the seven demands: an end to fighting on all fronts, the release of frozen Iranian funds and termination of the US naval blockade.

"It is in Washington's interest to accept these conditions,"

CONTINUED ON P4

Death by breath: How mining dust in Aravallis is killing residents

Silicosis has claimed more than 50 people's lives over the years in Syalodra



Oxygen cylinders stacked at the house of Manisha, whose husband, Manjit, died from silicosis PTI

ALIND CHAUHAN/PTI
Kotputli-Behror/
Sikar, September 20

Manisha (27) sits with a group of women on a mattress laid out in one corner of her house's veranda in Rajasthan's Sikar's Syalodra village. In the other corner, there are stacks of large oxygen cylinders, used by her 32-year-old husband, Manjeet, for breathing up until his recent death.

Manjeet was a labourer at a nearby stone crushing unit, and for more than

TAKEAWAYS

- » SC-appointed panel skipped several mining-affected villages
- » Syalodra was among villages reportedly missed by panel
- » Panel reviewed proposed boundaries of the Aravalli range
- » Mining has worsened pollution and respiratory diseases

three years, he suffered from a debilitating, incurable lung illness called silicosis. Its trigger: inhaling silica dust, fine particles

that are a by-product of rampant mining operations such as drilling, blasting, and stone crushing in the region. Silicosis has claimed more than 50 people's lives over the years in Syalodra, part of the Aravalli range, say residents.

However, the Supreme Court-appointed panel, which concluded its field visits to assess several aspects of the Aravallis on August 11, did not come to the village, much like it skipped going to many other mining-affected areas across

CONTINUED ON P4



NSE



NSE Mainboard - Equity, REITs, InvITs
NSE Emerge | NSE MF Invest | NSE Indices

NATIONAL STOCK EXCHANGE OF INDIA LIMITED is proposing, subject to receipt of requisite approvals, market conditions and other considerations, to make an initial public offer of its Equity Shares and has filed a red herring prospectus dated September 10, 2026 with the RoC. The RHP is made available on the website of the SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in as well as on the website of the BRLMs i.e., Kotak Mahindra Capital Company Limited at <https://investmentbank.kotak.com>, JM Financial Limited at www.jmfi.com, Morgan Stanley India Company Private Limited at www.morganstanley.com/india, Citigroup Global Markets India Private Limited at <https://www.citigroup.com/global/about-us/globalpresence/india>, HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India) Private Limited at www.business.hsbc.co.in, J.P. Morgan India Private Limited at www.jpmi.com, Anand Rathi Advisors Limited at www.anandrathiib.com, Avendus Capital Private Limited at www.avendus.com, Axis Capital Limited at www.axiscapital.co.in, DAM Capital Advisors Limited at www.damcapital.in, Equirus Capital Limited (formerly known as Equirus Capital Private Limited) at www.equirus.com, HDFC Bank Limited at www.hdfc.bank.in, ICICI Securities Limited at www.icicisecurities.com, IDBI Capital Markets & Securities Limited at www.idbicapital.com, IIFL Capital Services Limited (formerly known as IIFL Securities Limited) at www.iiflcapital.com, Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors Limited at www.motilaloswal.com, Nuvama Wealth Management Limited at www.nuvama.com, Pantomath Capital Advisors Private Limited at www.pantomathcapital.com, 360 ONE WAM Limited at www.360.one and SBI Capital Markets Limited at www.sbicap.com, the website of BSE at www.bseindia.com and the website of our Company at www.nseindia.com. Any potential investor should note that investment in equity shares involves a high degree of risk and for details relating to such risks, please see the section "Risk Factors" beginning on page 26 of the RHP. Potential investors should not rely on the DRHP for making any investment decision but should only rely on the information included in the RHP filed by the Company with the RoC, the SEBI and the Stock Exchange.

The Equity Shares offered in the Offer have not been and will not be registered under the United States Securities Act of 1933, as amended (the "U.S. Securities Act") or any other applicable law of the United States and, unless so registered, may not be offered or sold within the United States except pursuant to an exemption from, or in a transaction not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act and applicable state securities laws. Accordingly, the Equity Shares are being offered and sold (a) within the United States only to persons reasonably believed to be "qualified institutional buyers" (as defined in Rule 144A under the U.S. Securities Act and referred to in the RHP as "U.S. QIBs"; for the avoidance of doubt, the term "U.S. QIBs" does not refer to a category of institutional investor defined under applicable Indian regulations and referred to in the RHP as "QIBs" in transactions exempt from, or not subject to, the registration requirements of the U.S. Securities Act; and (b) outside of the United States in offshore transactions as defined in and in compliance with Regulation S under the U.S. Securities Act ("Regulation S") and the applicable laws of the jurisdiction where those offers and sales are made.

Road to relief for Burari

Rs 125-cr plan for 7.1-km road, 9.3-km drainage network

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, September 20

Burari’s long-standing road and drainage woes are set for a major overhaul, with the Delhi government drawing up a Rs 125-crore integrated plan to upgrade the entire 7.1-km Burari Road corridor and build a 9.3-km drainage network aimed at tackling waterlogging and improving connectivity.

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh inspected the Burari Road and adjoining drainage works on Sunday and reviewed the proposed plan with senior department officials.

Under the plan, the 3.2-km stretch between Outer Ring Road and Baba Colony and the Nathupura-Hiranki section will be reconstructed with bituminous roads, while the 3.9-km Baba Colony-Nathupura stretch will be developed as an RCC road at an estimated cost of Rs 39 crore. A central verge will also be constructed along the entire 7.1-km corridor.

Alongside the road works, the PWD has proposed a 9.3-km drainage network at an estimated cost of Rs 75 crore to tackle waterlogging in the area. The drainage work will include drains on both sides of the road between Amrit Vihar and Bengali Colony, besides drainage improvement on the Swaroop Nagar More-Burari Creek stretch.

The drainage work has already been tendered, while the road works



CLOSER LOOK

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are expected to be tendered within the next 10 days, according to the department.

“The entire corridor will be upgraded in an integrated manner. From the Outer Ring Road through Baba Colony and Nathu-

pura up to Hiranki, the road will be improved according to the requirements of each stretch, while drainage infrastructure will be strengthened simultaneously,” Singh said.

He directed officials to

coordinate the road and drainage works and maintain quality standards during execution.

“Every stretch must be executed with proper planning and quality. The road and drainage works should be coordinated so that residents do not face repeated disruption and the infrastructure delivers a durable solution for Burari,” he said. The department said the integrated approach was intended to prevent repeated digging of newly improved roads for drainage-related works and address road quality and waterlogging together.

Until reconstruction begins, PWD will undertake regular water sprinkling along the affected stretches as a dust-control measure.

MCD conducts cleanliness, plantation drives across Delhi

ANAMTA FATIMA
New Delhi, September 20

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Sunday conducted cleanliness, plantation and public awareness drives across several parts of the city, with a major campaign held around the Red Fort and Angoori Bagh in the Old Delhi Zone. The cleanliness drive, organised in collaboration with Vrikshit Foundation, saw nearly 400 volunteers participate. MCD teams and volunteers carried out sanitation activities at the Red Fort and adjoining areas, with the waste collected during the drive removed through around 10 auto-tippers.

A separate cleanliness and plantation drive was also held at Angoori Bagh Park near the Red Fort, aimed at improving the surroundings and increasing green cover. Officials also used the campaign to sensitise citizens and tourists about responsible waste disposal and keeping heritage and public spaces clean.

The drive was conducted under the guidance of Kanika, Deputy Commissioner, Old Delhi Zone. Councillor Suman Kumar Gupta also participated and appealed to residents and visitors to avoid littering and cooperate with the civic body.

Meanwhile, sanitation teams in the East Zone carried out deep cleaning along Swami Dayanand Marg. In the North Zone, special sanitation drives were conducted.

CULTURAL CONNECT



CM Rekha Gupta participates in the Haritalika Teej Mahotsav 2026 organised for the Nepali and Gorkhali community at Indira Gandhi Stadium in New Delhi on Sunday. Culture and Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra, yoga guru Swami Ramdev and Acharya Balkrishna were also present

MPOST

Delhi BJP protest over sanitation worker’s suicide

Seeks action against AAP councillor

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 20

BJP workers staged a protest at the AAP office here on Sunday, demanding action against the party’s MCD councillor from Trilokpuri over the suicide of a sanitation worker.

The Delhi BJP protesters, including Lok Sabha MP Yogender Chandoliya and state vice president Sunil Yadav, among others, demanded that AAP leaders expel councillor Vijay Kumar from the party. They alleged that Deepak, a sanitation worker at the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), was driven to take his own life after facing financial issues due to the councillor.

Deepak’s wife and minor daughter were accompanied by the BJP leaders during the protest.

The BJP, holding a protest outside the AAP Office, demanded dismissal of AAP Councillor Vijay Kumar and accused him of harassment and abetment of suicide.

The police detained the four protesters – Chan-

doliya, MLAs Ravi Kant Ujjainwal and Ravinder Negi, and Councillor Priyanka Gautam – at Tilak Marg police station. They were later released.

“Why are Arvind Kejriwal, Saurabh Bharadwaj and Kuldeep Kumar silent despite serious allegations against AAP Councillor Vijay Kumar of financially harassing an MCD sanitation worker and allegedly driving him to suicide?” Asked Chandoliya.

Along with workers from Mayur Vihar district, thousands of Delhi BJP state office-bearers and workers from the Scheduled Caste Morcha, Yuva Morcha, Kisan Morcha and Purvanchal Morcha participated in the protest, a Delhi BJP statement said.

Any form of injustice, exploitation or financial harassment of sanitation workers will not be tolerated, Chandoliya said and added that the BJP workers would continue their protest demanding an impartial investigation, action against those responsible and justice for the victim’s family.

Shokeen’s victory sparks celebrations in Peeragarhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 20

Independent candidate Deepanshu Shokeen’s victory in the Delhi University Students’ Union (DUSU) vice-presidential election led to celebrations in Peeragarhi on Sunday, with his family members and villagers assembling to mark his win. Shokeen secured 30,615 votes to defeat his nearest rival, ABVP’s Ishu

Maurya, by a margin of 13,705 votes. He was the only independent candidate to win one of the four central panel posts this year. At Peeragarhi, family members and villagers celebrated Shokeen’s victory with dancing and fireworks.

Shokeen’s grandmother said the family was happy that he had won and that students had encouraged him to contest and take up their issues.

Briefs

Medical store raided in city

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police, in coordination with the Drug Control Department, raided a medical store in outer north Delhi’s Pooth Khurd after receiving information that pregabalin capsules were allegedly being sold without prescriptions to people seeking the medicine for its intoxicating effects, officials said. The joint action was carried out on September 18 at Ambey Pharmacy on Pipeline Road near Satguru Dairy. Deputy Commissioner of Police (Outernorth) Shobhit Saxena said. Police said a decoy customer was sent to the shop with a Rs 500 note to purchase pregabalin without producing a prescription. The shopkeeper allegedly supplied the capsules, and the same currency note was subsequently recovered from his possession.

Class 7 student injured in pitbull attack

FARIDABAD: A pitbull dog attacked a class 7 student in NIT-3, biting him in 16 places, and leaving him seriously wounded, police said on Sunday. His family took him to BK Hospital, where doctors referred him to a higher medical centre. The boy is currently under treatment there. According to a complaint filed by Jitendra, a biryani cart owner, his son, Granth, was out with his cycle on Saturday evening and was talking to a friend in front of a house, when a pitbull charged at him.

Chandni Chowk’s historic Town Hall to get new life as Global Heritage Centre

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 20

The historic Town Hall complex in Chandni Chowk, which has remained largely unused since the MCD shifted its headquarters in 2010, will be redeveloped as a Global Heritage Centre under a 30-year MoU signed between the civic body and the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation (DTTDC) on Sunday.

The agreement, signed in the presence of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, covers the conservation and redevelopment of the Town Hall, Press Building and Park spread over around 12,180 square metres. The Grade-I heritage complex, constructed between 1860 and 1866, is proposed to house a museum and facilities for cultural and tourism-related activities.

Under the agreement, ownership of the property will remain with the MCD, while DTTDC will conduct a structural assessment, surveys and prepare a Detailed Project Report (DPR). The project will subsequently be taken up either through public investment or the



public-private partnership (PPP) route.

A Joint Working Group comprising officials from the DTTDC and MCD will review the project regularly. The MoU has an initial tenure of 30 years, extendable by another 30 years through mutual consent.

The redevelopment will follow an adaptive reuse approach, under which the heritage structure will be put to contemporary use while retaining its architectural character. The archival material, artefacts and

historical records associated with the Town Hall will remain with the MCD.

“The historic Town Hall in Chandni Chowk is not merely a building but an important part of Delhi’s rich history and heritage,” Gupta said, adding that the government would seek to preserve its historical and architectural identity while developing tourism and cultural activities at the site.

Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra said the redevelopment would add to the heritage tourism infrastructure

of Old Delhi. “Our effort is to make historical monuments more attractive and useful for domestic and international tourists while preserving their heritage,” he said. The MCD had used the Town Hall complex as its headquarters for several decades before shifting to the Dr S P Mukherjee Civic Centre on Minto Road in 2010. The site, located near Chandni Chowk and Old Delhi Railway Station, is among the prominent heritage properties in the Shahjahanabad area.

AT INNOTRANS 2026 IN BERLIN

Delhi Metro International Limited to make global debut

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 20

Delhi Metro International Limited, a wholly-owned subsidiary of DMRC, will make its global debut at InnoTrans 2026 in Berlin, showcasing its expertise in metro operations, consultancy, project management and advisory services.

At the biennial global rail transport trade fair, DMIL will engage with transit authorities, infrastructure companies, technology pro-

viders and other mobility stakeholders to explore partnerships and opportunities across the international urban transport ecosystem, according to a statement. The company has submitted five international bids in the last three months as part of its expansion plans, it said and added that it is exploring opportunities in West Asia and select European markets, while evaluating prospects in North America and keeping Africa on its watch list.

At InnoTrans 2026, DMIL will be present at Hall 7.2C, Stand 240, where it will showcase its capabilities and engage with government agencies, infrastructure partners, funders, developers and other stakeholders.

According to the corporation, the 2026 edition of the trade fair will focus on technologies transforming rail transport, including autonomous public transport, cybersecurity, robotics, 3D printing and



artificial intelligence.

DMIL CEO Sanjay Jamuar said the event would provide a platform to showcase the expertise of DMRC and DMIL globally and engage

with transit authorities, infrastructure partners and mobility leaders from across the world.

“Cities are looking for integrated, flexible and

future-ready mobility solutions. We see an opportunity to take our engineering expertise and real-world operational experience to international markets,” Jamuar said.

DMIL provides operations and maintenance, consultancy, project management and advisory services for metro, rail and urban transit projects in India and international markets, it said.

It will leverage Delhi Metro’s experience in planning,

construction and operations to support projects across their lifecycle, the statement said.

Delhi Metro operates a network of more than 416 km with over 300 stations and handles nearly 6.5 million passenger boardings daily, according to the DMRC.

DMIL will offer services ranging from feasibility studies and planning to implementation, testing, commissioning, operations and maintenance.

Death by breath: How mining the dust in Aravallis is killing residents

Continued from Page 1

Kotputli-Behror and Sikar districts, according to activists and residents. “We have spent most of our savings on my husband’s treatment. Yet, no one from the administration has talked to us or come to help,” says Manisha, a homemaker and mother of two young children.

The committee has been conducting an independent review of the Centre’s report on the definition and delineation of the Aravallis, where decades-long mining operations have exacerbated air pollution levels. This has caused several respiratory diseases among mine workers and people living close to mining sites.

The panel’s final report, to be submitted by November 30, can address these issues by establishing ecological boundaries in and around the range. But among the affected people, there is not much hope, especially after the SC recently refused to extend the report’s submission deadline by six months; the original deadline was August 31.

Death by breath Sanjay, 43, lives a few steps away from Manisha’s house. In July this year, he lost his brother, Manoj, who also worked at a stone crushing unit, to silicosis. The disease has claimed six members of his family.

“We do not have the money to move somewhere else. My kids have to live here and breathe the same poisonous air which has killed so many residents,” he says.

A 2023 study, ‘Prevalence of Silicosis in Stone

CLOSER LOOK

» The committee has been conducting an independent review of the Centre’s report on the definition and delineation of the Aravallis, where decades-long mining operations have exacerbated air pollution levels

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Carving and Sandstone Mining Industry in Rajasthan”, published in the Journal of Occupational and Environmental Medicine, examined the Rajasthan government’s online portal for the registration, certification, and disbursement of relief to silicosis-affected persons. The portal was launched under the Rajasthan Policy on Pneumoconiosis including Silicosis Detection, Prevention, Control and Rehabilitation - 2019.

At the time of the study, 23,436 cases of silicosis, including 6,876 deaths, had been certified on the portal. Data analysis of 4,977 silicosis cases, including 741 deaths, showed that detection of silicosis among districts with a preponderance of the stone carving industry was much higher.

The analysis also found that the prevalence of silicosis was the highest among people aged between 36 and 40.

The figures about silicosis cases and deaths, however, do not represent the true disease burden, which is considerably higher, says Kailash Meena, an environmentalist based in Sikar’s Neem Ka Thana town.

One key reason for undercounts is that people face several hurdles

in attaining certification of silicosis, given by community health centres or district hospitals based on medical examination and chest radiograph.

“The process requires patients and their family members to make multiple visits to hospitals. However, a lot of people cannot afford such frequent trips and fail to complete the process,” says Meena.

For instance, Syalodra resident Prem Devi, who belongs to a Scheduled Caste community and is in her early 50s, has registered herself thrice on the portal in the past three years with the help of her son. But each time, it has been cancelled.

“Once the registration has been done, we have to go to the hospital where an X-ray of the lungs is done. The X-ray is then sent to a doctor for examination, based on which the certification is granted. We never get to know who this doctor is or where his office is. Each time my X-ray has gone for an analysis, my registration has been cancelled,” she says.

For people like Prem Devi, a widow, certification is a lifeline, as they are bedridden on most days and have no source of income.

“Patients receive free medicines for the treat-

ment, Rs 5,000 every month, and other facilities if they get the certification,” says Meena.

The money becomes more significant once patients require oxygen support for breathing. Syalodra’s residents say each oxygen cylinder costs around Rs 1,000. In the days leading up to his death, Manjit consumed 12 oxygen cylinders per day.

The problem extends beyond Syalodra to mining-affected areas of Kotputli-Behror, including Jodhpura-Mohanpura village.

Standing next to a temple on a hilltop, Kailash Yadav, secretary of the Jodhpura Sangharsh Samiti, says most village residents have breathing issues.

The temple is adjacent to a mining site, operated by UltraTech Cement Limited.

The spot is dotted with JCBs busy excavating stones, which are sent via dumper trucks to a stone crushing unit installed next to the mine.

According to Yadav, explosions to shatter rocks are frequent at the site, even at night.

Rekha, who is the mother of a seven-year-old girl and lives not far from the mining site, says, “Dust from these mining activities is infecting our kids as well. My daughter now has asthma, and she has to use inhalers to breathe properly.”

An April 2023 survey in the village, conducted by the National Alliance of People’s Movement (NAPM) and the People’s Union for Civil Liberties (PUCL), gives a glimpse of the issue’s severity.

Out of nearly 928 individuals surveyed, 478 reported multiple health issues, including skin diseases, breathing problems, tuberculosis, and itchiness in the eyes.

In their final report about the survey, NAPM and PUCL conclude that the diseases could be “dust-induced from blasting activities” and that further investigation is required.

Noting the severe mining-related impacts on Jodhpura-Mohanpura residents, the Central Zone Bench of the National Green Tribunal (NGT), last November, ordered the Rajasthan government to constitute a committee to rehabilitate the entire village.

The order also banned blasts within 500 metres of the village, and directed UltraTech Cement Limited to pay Rs 20,000 for health-related harm.

The court order says, “A list of health check-ups has been filed” in which the medical officer has treated 298 persons; most of them are suffering from skin rashes, asthma, nose irritation, joint pain, deafness, allergy, breathlessness, eye irritation, allergy, etc., and the list is of 298 persons.”

Despite this, residents are yet to be rehabilitated, and no action has been taken to curb mining operations, says Yadav.

A response by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, and UltraTech Cement regarding the allegations is awaited.

No sign of relief

Rekha says the Aravalli committee was supposed to visit her village on August 8, but did not arrive.

“A group of us, along with my daughter, waited for the members for more than five hours. I wanted to tell them what mining has done to us,” she says.

The panel conducted its field visits between August 6 and 11, visiting nine districts in Delhi, Haryana, and Rajasthan, according to the Aravalli Virasat Jan Abhiyaan, a group of environmentalists, social activists, and others. Public hearings were held in Gurgaon, Alwar, Ajmer, and Udaipur.

A 2025 Forest Survey of India report identified 63 districts across Gujarat, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana and Delhi as part of the Aravalli range.

In its compliance report, submitted on August 31, the committee said it needed six more months to submit the final report. The additional time would allow the panel to bring together spatial, ecological, geological, hydrological, socio-economic, and stakeholder evidence before arriving at its conclusions regarding the Aravallis.

However, the SC denied the request and asked it to submit the final report by November 30.

“Let the panel work day and night to submit a report on the Aravalli issue,” said Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant while hearing the matter.

Yadav does not believe the panel members would visit Jodhpura-Mohanpura before submitting the final report.

“When they did not come during their first field visit, why would they come now? Their final report will not change anything for us,” he adds.

Manipur: Protests in Kangpokpi over detention of seven Kuki villagers

A few protesters suffered injuries during the agitation, official said

OUR CORRESPONDENT Imphal, September 20



Kuki community members stage a protest over the alleged detention of six villagers by security forces, in Kangpokpi, Sunday

Violent protests erupted in Manipur’s Kangpokpi district over the alleged detention of seven Kuki villagers by security forces, with agitators blocking roads and pelting stones at government vehicles, officials said on Sunday.

The protests continued from around 10 pm on Saturday till midnight in Motbung and nearby areas, during which agitators allegedly burnt tyres on roads and pelted stones at government vehicles, they said.

The protesters claimed that the seven villagers from Kholen were detained by security forces without being given any reason.

Kholen, located close to the Naga-dominated Chawangking village in the district, had recently come under attack by armed miscreants.

Security forces fired several rounds of tear gas shells to disperse the protesters, who also allegedly dug up portions of National Highway-2 (Imphal-Dimapur) at Motbung using heavy construction equipment to prevent security forces’ vehicles from moving, officials said.

A few protesters suffered injuries during the agitation and were admitted to a local hospital, they said.

A senior official said the seven village volunteers were subsequently released by the security forces, following which the protest ended.

“The situation in the district is under control now,” the official said.

The Kuki Inpi Manipur (KIM), the apex body of the Kuki community, meanwhile, condemned the detention of the seven villagers by the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF).

In a statement, KIM accused authorities of failing to take adequate action against those responsible for the killing of Kuki women by armed miscreants while detaining local civilians.

KIM described the detention as a “serious failure of law enforcement” and called for immediate action and accountability.

It also alleged that security forces used force against civilians who were peacefully protesting for their rights and security.

It also claimed that live rounds were fired and vehicles were vandalised during the incident.

Meanwhile, reacting to the release of detained village volunteers, members of a women’s organisation in Kakching district, Langmeidong Apunba Meira Paibi, staged a sit-in at Langmeidong demanding the release of all arrested Meitei village volunteers.

From page 1

SIR notices

Advani, 98, his daughter Pratibha and daughter-in-law Geetika were flagged as “unmapped with last SIR”, while his son Jayant was mapped successfully. All four are voters in the New Delhi Assembly constituency. Jaishankar and his wife, Kyoko Jaishankar, who are registered voters in the Sunehri Bagh area, were also issued notices under the same category.

Dhankhar and his wife Sudesh, whose voter records carry the address of the Vice President’s residence, received notices as well. Sandhu was issued a notice over a mismatch in his name, while his son Damnambir was flagged over a mismatch involving his parent’s name.

Sisodia, his wife Seema and their son Meer also received notices. Officials said the notice issued to Meer cited a discrepancy in his parent’s name, while Seema’s referred to a mismatch in her own name. The reason for Sisodia’s notice was not specified by the poll body.

At the New Moti Bagh polling station in the Delhi Cantonment constituency, which covers official residences of several senior government officials, 593 electors have received notices for different reasons.

The draft electoral roll published on August 31 contains 97,53,577 electors. This followed the removal of around 47 lakh entries from the earlier roll of 1,45,10,299 electors during the SIR process. Of the 33.13 lakh electors identified for notices, more than 31.63 lakh notices had been served by Saturday, according to the Delhi Chief Electoral Officer’s office.

The CEO office said the notices were system-generated

on the basis of “logical discrepancies” identified in the data and were intended to facilitate corrections in ECINET. It rejected suggestions that receiving a notice meant an immediate threat to a voter’s registration, saying, “there is no existential crisis as is being brought out in social and print”.

Sibal, who along with his wife received notices under the “unmapped with last SIR” category, criticised the exercise and described the SIR as “special intensive deletion” of votes.

The poll authorities said voters who receive notices can submit replies and supporting documents to the concerned Electoral Registration Officer or Booth Level Officer. The list of documents prescribed by the Election Commission is indicative rather than exhaustive, allowing officials to consider other relevant evidence on a case-by-case basis.

The authorities have also said no voter can be deleted without an opportunity to be heard and a proper, speaking and appealable order.

The name of economist and former chairman of the Prime Minister’s Economic Advisory Council Bibek Debroy also appeared in the notice list under the “unmapped” category. Debroy died in November 2024 and was a voter in the New Delhi constituency. A senior poll official said his death had been noted and his name would be excluded from the final roll.

In another case, Gupta’s electoral entry was validated after officials examined the documents and facts submitted by her. Her name has been earmarked for inclusion in the final roll for Shalimar Bagh.

The claims and objections process will remain open until September 30. Voters receiving notices have been asked to submit their responses and doc-

uments by October 29, when disposal of the notices is scheduled to be completed. The final electoral roll is scheduled to be published on November 4.

The Delhi CEO office has published booth-wise notice lists online, enabling voters to check whether their names have been flagged and the reason recorded against their entries. Those whose names are absent from the draft roll can separately seek inclusion by submitting Form 6.

Valarivan stars

medals at the third and fourth Asian Mixed Martial Arts Championships this year.

In cricket, India defeated Bangladesh by 114 runs in Nishin to reach the women’s final. Shafali Verma struck her maiden T20 International century, reaching the landmark in 49 balls, as India posted 195/4. Bangladesh could not mount a successful chase. India will meet Sri Lanka in Tuesday’s final, repeating the previous edition’s title clash.

The hockey teams also produced emphatic opening victories. The women’s side defeated Uzbekistan 19-0, with 22-year-old Deepika Sehrawat scoring a record eight goals. The men beat Indonesia 13-1, with Dilpreet Singh scoring four.

India’s table tennis teams opened with 3-0 victories over Indonesia. The women then beat Singapore 3-2, while the men lost 0-3 to Iran. In badminton, PV Sindhu, Unnati Hooda and Tanvi Sharma helped India beat Kazakhstan 3-0 without dropping a game. Japan awaits in the quarterfinals.

Quimcy D’Souza narrowly missed two teqball bronze medals. She lost 0-2 to Japan’s Yuina Sakamoto in women’s singles before also losing the mixed doubles bronze match with Mohamed Anas Beg to Vietnam. MMA fighter Varun Sanyal

was ruled medically unfit after passing out during a sauna session. Swimmer Rishabh Das finished sixth in the 100m backstroke final in 54.77 seconds, while wushu’s Suraj Singh Mayanglam placed 11th in the men’s changquan final with 9.683 points.

BMW plunges

construction site. CCTV footage recorded around 5:03 am showed the vehicle going over the edge, flipping in the air and crashing into the work area below.

All four occupants were rescued from the badly damaged vehicle and taken to the civic-run Nair Hospital. Three were declared dead on arrival, while Aditya Kalpeshwar Oswal, 23, was admitted to the trauma ward in critical condition.

The deceased were identified as Shanay Gajjal, 21, Dhairya Darshan Seth, 17, and Aditya Jakasniya, 19. The four were residents of Silvassa and were reportedly students of NMIMS College in Juhu, living in paying guest accommodation. Reports said they were returning after visiting Marine Drive. Relatives in Mumbai reached the hospital, while the victims’ parents travelled from Gujarat.

Police said the exact circumstances remain under investigation, and the survivor’s statement is yet to be recorded. It was also not immediately established who was driving.

The 10.58-km Coastal Road connects Marine Drive with the Worli end of the Bandra-Worli Sea Link. On September 3, Mumbai Police had booked several supercars over alleged racing in the Coastal Road tunnel.

Modi mimicry

to meet you” and asked him to “tell me more”. The comedian later said, “Maa ko kursi do, maa”, while pointing towards

the audience.

The performance triggered strong reactions from the BJP, with several leaders objecting to what they described as mockery of the prime minister and his late mother.

Union minister Piyush Goyal described the act as “cheap political theatre” and referred to Gandhi as “Asanskari naraz fufa (uncultured disgruntled uncle)”. “The irony writes itself. The need to come on stage every now and then just to drag Prime Minister Modi ji’s name into cheap political theatre never fails to amaze me,” Goyal wrote on X, asking Gandhi to “look in the mirror”.

Union minister Kiren Rijiju said he had not imagined that a party that had been in power for nearly six decades would become a “circus” entertaining its supporters. He also questioned Gandhi over the portrayal of an elderly woman and Modi in the performance, while sharing a video of Modi asking for a chair for an elderly woman at one of his programmes.

BJP national general secretary Smriti Irani posted a Hindi saying on X: “Jab nash manuj per chata hai, pehle vivek mar jaata hai” (When doom looms over a person, it is his conscience that dies first). BJP national secretary Sandeep Pathak described the performance as an expression of “desperation” and the “growing intellectual bankruptcy” of the Congress.

Union Education Minister Prahlad Joshi called the episode “shameful and disgusting”, alleging that Gandhi and the Congress had mocked and insulted Modi’s late mother. Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami said, “A mother is not a subject of politics,” while arguing that political opponents could be criticised without making remarks about a mother.

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis said Gandhi could consider stand-up comedy as a career, claiming that this was the “only job left” for him and that he had already left his political party “unemployed”.

Congress and other opposition leaders rejected the criticism. Congress leader Raashid Alvi said the incident was “mimicry and nothing else”. He argued that the BJP should also recall remarks made by Modi about senior Congress leader Sonia Gandhi, which he described as insulting.

TMC MP Mahua Moitra defended the performance as a democratic right, saying people should be able to “fearlessly lampoon a PM”. AAP leader Saurabh Bharadwaj said BJP leaders had themselves made insulting remarks about Gandhi and his family and argued that those demanding respect should extend it to political opponents.

Congress leader Bhupesh Baghel said every mother deserved respect, asking why similar objections were not raised when the mothers of Gandhi and other leaders were allegedly targeted.

Congress MP Imraan Masood said the programme had “shattered eardrums” of BJP leaders and said they would respond when elections arrived. Congress leader TS Singh Deo drew a distinction between criticism and abusive language, saying mimicry or joking criticism should not be objectionable but abusive language in public discourse was unacceptable.

AICC general secretary Ghulam Ahmad Mir said the programme had received an “overwhelming response”, claiming that more than 200,000 young people had attended events under the initiative across India and Madhya Pradesh.

Gandhi’s Indore session

focused on issues including the cost of education, employment opportunities and concerns affecting students.

Iran

Rezaei said, adding that Trump’s threats would not change Iran’s position.

He said Iranian military assessments indicated another US attack was “very much on the cards”, although Tehran was pursuing a strategy “to bring this war to an end as soon as possible”. Iran has adjusted its military planning after earlier clashes and is now focusing on US naval forces operating from the Persian Gulf through the Gulf of Oman to the Arabian Sea.

According to Tehran Times, Rezaei also claimed Iran had recently tested a multi-warhead anti-ship missile near a US vessel or aircraft carrier. He warned that any further US attack could prompt Iranian strikes on American military bases, commercial interests and companies in the region.

The conflict began on February 28 with coordinated US-Israeli air strikes that killed Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei and senior officials.

Iran subsequently attacked US bases across the Gulf, leading to further exchanges.

Qatar and Pakistan have continued mediation efforts. Pakistan’s Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi is expected in Tehran, although Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmaeil Baghaei said he was unaware of any specific US proposal.

Rezaei also said Iran had no decision to leave the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty.

He said Tehran’s nuclear doctrine remained unchanged, though continued US actions could eventually prompt a reassessment.

Briefs

UP: SP MP booked under SC/ST Act

SANT KABIR NAGAR: Samajwadi Party MP Laxmikant alias Pappu Nishad has been booked under the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act following a complaint alleging assault, caste-based abuse and criminal intimidation, while another FIR was registered against unidentified persons on the MP's complaint over alleged damage to his vehicle, officials said.

Prez Murmu on 3-day Gujarat visit

NEW DELHI: President Droupadi Murmu will be on a visit Gujarat during September 21-23, her office said on Sunday. She will preside over the 72nd National Film Awards at Ekta Nagar, Kevadia, on September 22, it said in a statement. On September 23, the President will grace the 75th annual convocation at the Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda at Vadodara.

‘Prioritise people’s concerns’

SRINAGAR: National Conference president Farooq Abdullah on Sunday asked MLAs to highlight the issues and demands of people in their respective constituencies during the Autumn Session of Jammu and Kashmir Assembly.

He was chairing a meeting of MLAs from the ruling National Conference, the Congress, the CPI (M) and Independents supporting the government a day before the start of the Autumn Session.

Ex-BJP MP Pratap Simha booked

MYSURU: Police said on Sunday that they had registered an FIR against former BJP MP Pratap Simha and others over an alleged provocative speech during a Ganesha idol procession in T Narasipura.

The case was registered at the T Narasipura police station on Saturday after a PSI filed a complaint alleging that Simha made derogatory remarks over a microphone targeting Inspector Dhananjay during the Ganesha idol procession held in the town on Friday.

Bribe: CID inspector arrested

KURUKSHETRA: The Haryana State Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) on Sunday arrested a CID inspector while allegedly accepting a bribe of Rs 5 lakh.

According to the ACB, the accused, Inspector Rajesh Kumar, posted with Haryana CID, had allegedly demanded money from a transporter in return for allowing vehicles carrying mining material to operate without obstruction.

HOSTEL CRISIS

‘Why students forced to live in unsafe PGs’: Rahul slams govt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 20

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday hit out at the Modi government over the issue of hostel facilities for students asking why they are “forced to live in unsafe PGs” and also sought to know the status of the investigation into the Satya Niketan building collapse incident. In a social media post, Gandhi shared pictures from the interaction he had on Saturday in Indore with the family of a student from Madhya Pradesh who died in the Satya Niketan building collapse in Delhi on September 6, in which seven people, including students, were killed.

Among those killed was 21-year-old Arpit Jaj, a native of Dewas in Madhya Pradesh. Gandhi invited Jaj's family on stage during his youth outreach programme ‘Chhatron Ki Goonj’ in Indore on Saturday.

In his post in Hindi on X on Sunday, the Congress leader said, “What was that innocent soul's fault? This is the question being asked, with tear-filled eyes, by the family that lost their son, Arpit Jaj, in the Satya Niketan tragedy.”

Had there been good, safe hostels, they would not have been forced to house their child in such



Congress MP Rahul Gandhi addresses the ‘Chhatron ki Goonj’ event, in Indore PTI

KEY POINTS

- » Gandhi invited one student's family on stage during his youth outreach programme ‘Chhatron Ki Goonj’ in Indore on Saturday
- » The system's irresponsibility and corruption have snuffed out lives full of dreams and devastated families filled with hope, Gandhi alleged

a dangerous place, the leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha said.

And had safety standards truly been adhered to, perhaps this tragedy, one that neither the students nor their parents could have ever imagined, would never have occurred, he said.

The system's irresponsibility and corruption have snuffed out lives full of dreams and devastated families filled with hope, Gandhi alleged.

Earlier in the day, he also flagged the issue of lack of hostels for female students and sought answers from Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the problem being faced by them.

Gandhi cited the remarks by a female student during his ‘Chhatron Ki Goonj’ event in Indore to corner the government.

“The government has money to light diyas - why not for our hostels? This question was asked of me

yesterday by a female student in Indore. She came to the city from a village to study,” he said recalling the interaction.

“There's no hostel, so she has to stay in a PG. Just to stay safe, lakhs are spent. The worry of monthly rent, and the fear of becoming homeless - she has to study amidst all this,” Gandhi said in his post in Hindi.

Many girls drop out of their studies for this very reason - because there's no place to live, he said.

“And what about the housing allowance? It doesn't increase with inflation, and on top of that, it falls prey to corruption. Narendra Modi ji - Do you have any answer to that little girl's question?” the former Congress chief asked.

Cong: SIR really means ‘Shah Instigated Removal’ of voters

In Phase-1 and Phase-2, names of 7.8 crore voters were deleted, claims Opposition party

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 20

The Congress on Sunday flagged the issue of large-scale deletions during the ongoing Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls being carried out by the Election Commission, alleging that the SIR is actually a massive “Shah Instigated Removal” of voters and an “assault on the Constitution”.

The Opposition party said there is abundant evidence to prove that large-scale deletions across states are overwhelmingly those of voters belonging to the most economically and socially disadvantaged and deprived sections of the society.

Congress general secretary in-charge commu-

THE DELETION RATE AS A PROPORTION OF THE PRE-SIR ELECTORAL ROLL WORKS OUT TO 13 PER CENT

nications Jairam Ramesh said the Election Commission of India (ECI) began Phase-1 of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process of the electoral rolls in June 2025 in Bihar and subsequently Phase-2 was launched in November 2025 across nine states and three Union Territories (UTs).

In Phase-1 and Phase-2, names of 7.8 crore voters were deleted, Ramesh said in a statement.

Nagaland's draft electoral roll after SIR retains 11.99lakh voters, excludes 1.59L

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Kohima, September 20

Nagaland's draft electoral roll was published on Sunday with nearly 1.59 lakh of the 13.57 lakh voters excluded from the pre-SIR list.

The Chief Electoral Officer's (CEO's) office said the draft roll has 11.99 lakh names, with the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise finding 29,944 electors from the

previous list deceased, 1.23 lakh absent or permanently shifted, and 5,059 enrolled at multiple places.

The enumeration phase of the SIR of electoral rolls was held in the state from August 16 to September 14.

The CEO office said the absent/shifted/other category includes electors who became voters in other states or Union Territories, could not be

The deletion rate as a proportion of the pre-SIR electoral roll works out to 13 per cent, he said.

Phase-3 commenced in 16 states and three UTs in mid-2026, he said.

“The deletion rate works out to over 17 per cent 2. An additional 5.43 crore voters have been issued notices demanding additional documentation to have their names retained on the electoral roll. The risk of deletion rate works to another 15 per cent. This is an unusually high proportion that reflects structural flaws in the entire SIR process,” Ramesh said.

After such a large round of deletion, how can there still be so many additional voters who need to “be verified”, he asked.

Ishan Anand to get ‘respectable role’ in BSP: Mayawati

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Lucknow, September 20

Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) supremo Mayawati on Sunday said only one of her younger brother Anand Kumar's children, Ishan Anand, will be given responsibility within the party.

Mayawati said Akash Anand, who was the party's chief national coordinator until a few weeks back, and his sister Deepika would be kept away from the party and there would be no change in her decision on this.

About a week back, former Uttar Pradesh chief minister had said that neither of Anand Kumar's sons, Akash and Ishan, would be allowed to hold any post in the BSP, which has been in the news the past few weeks due to the ongoing family tussle.

Yogi: Sanatan tradition embraces diverse ideas

Attacks Ansari and Rahul Gandhi

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

Lucknow, September 20

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said India's identity and cultural heritage were deeply rooted in the Sanatan tradition and asserted that the tradition had always welcomed good ideas from different parts of the world.

Addressing the concluding session of ‘Perna Vimarsh-2026’ at Gautam Buddha University in Greater Noida, Yogi said people in India took pride in the country's rich tradition, deities, pilgrimage centres and cultural heritage. “Sanatan belongs to everyone,” he said, adding that the tradition had provided shelter to different communities and sects during times of crisis.

Yogi said Sanatan tradition had historically accepted diverse ideas. “If a good idea comes from

anywhere, it should be welcomed,” he said, while criticising what he described as a narrow “yours and mine” mindset.

Referring to an old statement by former vice-president Hamid Ansari, Yogi said a person who had held a constitutional position should not have made such remarks. He alleged that such statements created a wrong image of India and encouraged an “anti-India” mindset. He also accused some people of attempting to insult India through half-truths.

Yogi also criticised Congress leader Rahul Gandhi while speaking about respect for women and the cultural importance of the mother figure.

He said Indian culture had traditionally followed the principle of giving priority to others and referred to the ethos of “Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam”.

Aravallis under ‘gravest of threats’ by govt’s moves: Oppn

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 20

Senior Congress leader and former environment minister Jairam Ramesh on Sunday claimed that the Aravallis are under the “gravest of threats” by the Modi government's decision to have them redefined and hoped that the High Powered Committee set up by the Supreme Court will reject the Centre's moves.

Ramesh alleged that the Modi government is “hellbent” on redefining the Aravallis and hoped that the Supreme Court will stand firm.

His remarks came after a three-part news agency report on the environmental impact of mining on the Aravallis.

“The Aravallis are under the gravest of threats by the Modi govt's moves to have them redefined so as to allow mining, real estate and other projects. Before the chief

WITH THEIR NATURAL CRACKS AND FISSURES, THE ARAVALLI HILLS HAVE THE POTENTIAL TO PUT TWO MILLION LITRES OF WATER PER HECTARE INTO THE GROUND EVERY YEAR, ACCORDING TO EXPERTS

justice of India retires on Feb 9, 2027, we may well know what will happen to these moves. Fingers crossed,” Ramesh said on X.

“Hopefully the High Powered Committee set up by the Supreme Court and given a deadline of Nov 30, 2026, to submit its report will reject the Modi govt's moves to redefine the Aravallis. Otherwise, there will be more such ecocides,” the Congress leader said.

With their natural cracks and fissures, the Aravalli hills have the potential to put two million litres of water per hectare into the ground every year, according to experts.

This makes the range a critical water recharge zone for several areas in north-west India, where the Aravallis stretch from Delhi to Gujarat.

But decades-long mining of sedimentary rocks, such as limestone and marble, along the range has allegedly led to numerous stone quarries and stone crushers set up near or on riverbeds and water bodies.

This imperils the water security that the Aravallis once provided.

News agency reported last month on how mining has impacted Rajasthan's Kotas-Behror and Sikar districts. It also explored how mining dust in the Aravallis is killing residents.

Akhilesh: Reduce BJP's vote by 27K in every constituency

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Lucknow, September 20

Virtually sounding the poll bugle for the 2027 UP Assembly elections, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday said that his party will work to “reduce the BJP's vote by 27,000” in every Assembly constituency.

Speaking to reporters in Lucknow, Yadav said, “Today, we held a meeting with all the office-bearers and members of the state executive committee.

We all have decided to work towards increasing our vote count by 27,000 in every Assembly Constituency by 2027. In other words, reducing the BJP's vote count by 27,000.

“To achieve this, we will need to utilise technology, visit people at their homes to listen to them and understand their concerns, and speak about securing justice and dignity. We will continue to work on this together,” Yadav said.

Assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh are scheduled to be held in 2027.

The SP chief also said that people from all walks of life are aggrieved.

Farmers have been “betrayed”, he alleged, adding that promises were made to double their income, but that has not happened. The prices of diesel, petrol, pesticides, medicines, fertilisers, and DAP (fertilisers) have all been hiked, he further said.

“When the crops are ready, farmers are not receiving fair prices for them. The profits generated from sugarcane farming and the associated trade are being pocketed by others. The farmers themselves are not receiving their share of these profits.

Navies of India, SL take part in bilateral maritime exercise

13th edition of maritime exercise ‘SLINEX-26’ being conducted at Visakhapatnam

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 20

Navies of India and Sri Lanka are currently engaged in a bilateral exercise in Visakhapatnam, aiming to strengthen maritime cooperation and foster interoperability, officials said on Sunday.

The 13th edition of the Sri Lanka-India bilateral maritime exercise, ‘SLINEX-26’, is being conducted from September 17-21, a spokesperson of the Indian Navy said.

The exercise commenced with the harbour



phase, and will be followed by the sea phase.

INS Kavaratti, an indigenous anti-submarine warfare corvette, and INS Jyoti, a fleet tanker, are partic-

ipating from the Indian Navy, while SLNS Sindurula represents the Sri Lankan Navy, the official said.

Conceptualised in

CLOSER LOOK

- » The exercise commenced with the harbour phase, and will be followed by the sea phase
- » Conceptualised in 2005, SLINEX has evolved into an important forum for fostering maritime cooperation, interoperability and mutual understanding between the two navies

2005, SLINEX has evolved into an important forum for fostering maritime cooperation, interoperability and mutual understanding between the two navies.

The harbour phase, being conducted under the

aegis of the Eastern Naval Command, commenced with an opening ceremony and reception onboard INS Kavaratti for the visiting crew of SLNS Sindurula.

The phase includes professional interactions, cross-deck visits, sharing of best

practices, yoga, sports and cultural activities, the spokesperson said.

The subsequent sea phase will focus on enhancing operational synergy and interoperability through coordinated activities at sea.

Aligned with India's vision of ‘MAHASAGAR’, ‘SLINEX-26’ reinforces India's commitment to a secure, stable and inclusive maritime environment and further consolidates the enduring maritime partnership between India and Sri Lanka, the spokesperson said.

IAF CHIEF HAILS JOINT AIR EXERCISE

‘Milestone’: In a first, Japanese fighter jets fly from Indian soil

MPOST BUREAU
Jodhpur, September 20

Japanese fighter aircraft operating from Indian soil for the first time marks a major milestone in defence cooperation between India and Japan. Air Chief Marshal A P Singh said here on Sunday during an ongoing bilateral air exercise.

The exercise, being held at Air Force Station, Jodhpur from September 9-22, involves Indian Air Force frontline aircraft, including the indigenous Tejas, Su-30MKI and Rafale, and Japan Air Self-Defense Force’s F-2A fighters.

Japanese Air Self-Defense Force Chief of Staff General Takehiro Morita said the deployment of Japanese fighters to India had taken defence cooperation beyond simply conducting exercises and demonstrated the ability to deploy air assets across the Indo-Pacific region.

The Japanese air chief flew a Tejas jet with a pilot, while Air Chief Marshall Singh flew solo on a Tejas jet as part of their sorties under the Indo-Japan bilateral air exercise, Veer Guardian-2026.

In a gesture of mutual respect and partnership, the two air force chiefs observed a badge exchange.

“This exercise, especially because the Japanese fighters are operating from Indian soil for the first time, is a great milestone in



Chief of the Air Staff Air Marshal AP Singh, with an official of the Japan Air Self-Defense Force during the joint air exercise ‘Veer Guardian 2026’

KEY POINTS

- » The exercise is being held at Air Force Station, Jodhpur from September 9-22
- » It involves Indian Air Force frontline aircraft including the indigenous Tejas, Su-30MKI and Rafale, and Japan Air Self-Defense Force’s F-2A fighters
- » 3- In a gesture of mutual respect and partnership, the two air force chiefs observed a badge exchange

our history of our relationship and our partnership,” Singh said, addressing a press conference after the sortie.

He said the exercise reflected the deepening strategic partnership between the two countries, built on mutual respect, professional trust and a shared commitment to peace and stability.

“When we do exercises together, we learn from each other. We fly together. We train together. So both sides improve together,” Singh said, adding that such exercises provide an opportunity to understand each other’s operational practices and enhance capabilities.

Japanese air chief Morita said advanced

training would develop mutual understanding, strengthen trust and enhance sustained practical cooperation between the two countries.

Morita said Tejas stands as a symbol of India’s technological innovation and embodies the ‘Make in India’ initiative. While flying, he said he reflected on the efforts of many people, both in the military and industry, who contributed to its development.

“I will remember it not only as a truly invaluable experience, but also as a powerful symbol of the trust, confidence, and partnership that have been built between our two air services over many years,” he said.

Saini directs smooth paddy procurement

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, September 20

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday directed officials to ensure smooth paddy procurement and warned that strict action would be taken if any negligence was found during the process.

Addressing a meeting at the Babain Market Committee office, Saini reviewed procurement arrangements with farmers, arhtiyas, traders, rice millers and administrative officials. He directed the Food and Supplies Department and mandi authorities to ensure that farmers faced no difficulty during the procurement season.

The chief minister said the Meri Fasal Mera Byora (MFMB) portal would be reopened from September 21 to 27 to allow farmers whose applications had not been submitted to complete the process. Farmers whose crop verification is pending have been advised to submit written requests to their

THE HARYANA MFMB PORTAL WOULD BE REOPENED FROM SEPT 21 TO 27

respective Sub-Divisional Magistrates (SDMs) for completing the verification.

Saini said information had been received about pending crop verification and applications that had not been submitted through the MFMB portal. The decision to reopen the portal was taken to address these issues, he said.

He said the government had been implementing various measures for farmers and claimed that all 24 crops grown in Haryana were being procured at Minimum Support Price (MSP).

Saini said vegetable growers were being covered under the Bhavantar Bhardpai Yojana, while eligible farmers receive Rs 6,000 annually directly into their bank accounts under the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi Yojana.

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, September 20

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Sunday said the Mukh Mantri Sehat Yojna has provided health security to 54 lakh families, with 1.26 crore health cards distributed under the scheme.

Addressing a card distribution ceremony in Mohali, Mann said the scheme provides cashless treatment of up to Rs 10 lakh without imposing any financial burden on beneficiaries. So far, Rs 1,310 crore has been spent on the treatment of more than seven lakh patients, he said.

The chief minister said the objective was to ensure that no family is forced into debt or financial distress because of illness. Beneficiaries can avail themselves of treatment at government or private hospitals of their choice, he added.

“Our objective is not merely to provide treat-

IIT Bombay student suicide: Crime Branch likely to summon professor

Professor booked for abetment as kin allege institutional harassment

MPOST BUREAU
Mumbai, September 20

The Crime Branch, which has taken over the probe into the alleged suicide of a 22-year-old IIT Bombay student, is likely to summon a professor from the premier institute and others for questioning, officials said on Sunday.

The professor has been named as an accused in the case, which will be handled by the Assistant Commissioner of Police (Detection), they said.

Sahil Ravindra Wakode was found hanging from the ceiling fan in his room in Hostel Number 4 on the Powai campus of the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Bombay on Friday evening, hours after he was allegedly caught using a mobile phone and



Family of the 22-year-old IIT Bombay student, who died by suicide, arrive at Powai Police Station in Mumbai on Saturday

ChatGPT during a mid-semester examination, they said.

Wakode, a native of Maharashtra’s Yavatmal district, was a second-year BTech student in the Energy Science and Engineering department.

The Powai police on Saturday registered a

First Information Report (FIR) under Section 108 (abetment of suicide) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) and the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act based on a complaint filed by the student’s parents.

The family has alleged

that Wakode was subjected to institutional harassment and caste-based discrimination before he took the extreme step, which triggered a protest by students on the campus. The protesters claimed that Wakode faced severe pressure and threats of academic suspension.

The case was transferred to the Crime Branch on Saturday night.

The Crime Branch is likely to summon the accused professor and others for questioning, an official said.

According to a statement from IIT Bombay, the student had allegedly uploaded the examination question paper to ChatGPT to seek answers during the exam. However, no disciplinary action was initiated against him, it said.

Journalist Payal Mehta passes away in Mumbai

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, September 20

Payal Mehta, a senior journalist with CNN-News18, passed away in the early hours of Sunday in Mumbai.

Mehta (46) was on a visit to Mumbai when she developed uneasiness early in the morning. She was rushed to a hospital, where she later passed away.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Home Minister Amit Shah, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, and other Union ministers condoled Mehta’s death.

In a post on X, senior journalist Sheela Bhatt said, “On a visit to Mumbai, she developed uneasiness. Around 2 am she was taken to the hospital. Before any treatment could be administered, her pulse went silent”.

Mehta was known for covering the Parliament, the government and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

“Payal Mehta Ji was a hardworking journalist who remained firmly connected to the ground, bringing a deep understanding of national issues to her reporting,” Modi said in a post on X.

He emphasised that beyond her work, Mehta would be remembered for the kindness and warmth with which she touched many lives.

Briefs

CM: Hry to reconstruct 150 schools

KURUKSHETRA: Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini said 150 schools across the state have been identified for reconstruction at Rs 400 crore. Addressing a programme in Ladwa, he announced Rs 21 lakh for Bir Kheri village, Rs 2 lakh for its library and Rs 50 lakh for Anthedi’s community centre.

Raj AGTF nabs two ‘gangsters’

JAIPUR: Rajasthan Police’s Anti-Gangster Task Force arrested alleged sharp shooters Jaskaran Singh and Rajinder Singh, linked to “Lawrence-Arzoobishnoi gang”, in Jodhpur. Both, wanted in two murder cases, carried a Rs 5 lakh reward each and face 12 cases in Punjab.

Beed cop booked for rape

BEED: An FIR was registered against assistant sub-inspector Ganesh Rathod for allegedly raping a woman at her home, an official said. Rathod, posted at Wadwani Police Station here, had allegedly promised to settle a case against her before visiting her residence. He is currently absconding, the official said.

Tech integration takes Himachal horticulture value chain to next level

State govt also focuses on scientific utilisation of apple waste, promotion of value-added products

ASHWANI SHARMA
Shimla, September 20

Himachal Pradesh, where horticulture accounts for 22 per cent of the value of agricultural produce and covers 26 per cent of the state’s agricultural area, is increasingly using technology to strengthen the horticulture value chain, from procurement and processing to marketing, with an aim to improve returns for growers.

Apples remain at the heart of the state’s horticulture economy, accounting for nearly 80 per cent of its total fruit production.



Taking a significant step towards modernising the sector, the Himachal Pradesh Horticultural Produce Marketing and Processing Corporation Ltd (HPMC), a government PSU, has diversified its

operations while using technology to improve efficiency and transparency. The move has also opened up greater opportunities for value addition and business diversification.

THE CM SAID THE OBJECTIVE WAS TO ENSURE THAT NO FAMILY IS FORCED INTO DEBT OR FINANCIAL DISTRESS BECAUSE OF ILLNESS

ment but to ensure that no family is forced into debt or financial distress because of illness. Healthcare should not become a luxury available only to those who can afford it,” Mann said.

He said the scheme covers specialised and high-cost procedures, while the health department has listed services including dialysis, cancer treatment, cardiac procedures, kidney and liver transplantation, knee replacement, cataract surgery, C-section deliveries and emergency care.

Health Minister Balbir Singh said the scheme was supporting access to essen-

tial healthcare services and cited the first kidney transplant at Rajindra Hospital, Patiala, performed entirely under the programme. He also highlighted a heart procedure performed on a 37-year-old woman under the scheme.

Mann said the state’s network of 1,100 Aam Aadmi Clinics had recorded around 5.5 crore outpatient visits, bringing primary healthcare closer to residential areas.

Under the next phase, Sehat Cards will be distributed directly to eligible families through camps in more than 1,800 villages. Those unable to attend camps will be covered through door-to-door delivery by Sehat Mitras and ASHA workers.

The scheme currently covers 2,356 treatment packages through more than 900 empanelled hospitals across Punjab and Chandigarh, including government and private facilities.

INSIGHT

- » HPMC, a government PSU, has diversified its operations while using technology to improve efficiency and transparency
- » The move has also opened up greater opportunities for value addition and business diversification

driven horticulture value chain “from Orchard to Market”.

Under the new system, growers register online and procurement-related details are recorded through a digital portal. The initiative is aimed at improving transparency, accountability, record management and operational efficiency in the procurement process.

The scale of procurement highlights the importance of the system. As of September 18, 2026, HPMC had procured 4,188.504 metric tonnes of apples from growers under the Market Intervention Scheme (MIS)-2026.

The procurement is being carried out exclusively through the online portal at the prescribed market intervention price of Rs 12 per kilogram. For growers, the institutionalised and transparent mechanism is expected to provide greater clarity and confidence in the procurement process.

The state government is also focusing on the scientific utilisation of apple waste and the promotion of value-added products to minimise wastage, strengthen processing, create employment and diversify the horticulture economy.

Another measure aimed at improving transparency and uniformity in the apple trade is the introduction of a universal carton system. Under the system, apples are packed in standardised 20-kg cartons, with specifications prescribed for different grades.

The system is intended to reduce discrepancies in packing, bring greater transparency to transactions and protect growers’ interests. Along with digital procurement, standardised packaging is expected to add another layer of accountability to the apple value chain.

EDITORIAL

Walking the Liquidity Tightrope

India's banking system has moved from a shortage of liquidity to an extraordinary abundance of it, leaving the Reserve Bank of India with a problem that central banks often find harder to solve than creating liquidity in the first place. Banking-system surplus liquidity touched a record Rs 11.6 lakh crore earlier this month before declining as tax outflows and foreign-exchange interventions removed some cash. The RBI has now turned to a powerful instrument rarely used for this purpose in recent years: outright sales of government securities through open market operations. It sold Rs 50,000 crore of bonds in the first tranche on September 17 and has scheduled further sales as part of a Rs 1 lakh crore programme. The return to auction-based bond sales after nine years is more than a technical adjustment. It signals that the central bank believes the surplus has become sufficiently persistent to require durable withdrawal rather than merely temporary parking of funds.

Excess liquidity is not inherently undesirable. Adequate cash in the banking system keeps money markets functioning, prevents sudden spikes in borrowing costs and gives banks room to support credit. The difficulty begins when there is far more money than the system requires. Overnight interest rates can then remain below the policy rate, weakening the RBI's ability to transmit monetary policy. Banks awash with funds also have less incentive to compete aggressively for deposits, while unusually easy financial conditions can complicate the fight against inflation. This explains why the RBI has simultaneously been using variable rate reverse repo auctions to absorb large quantities of cash. The objective is not to engineer a liquidity shortage, but to bring money-market conditions closer to the monetary-policy stance that the repo rate is supposed to represent.

The challenge lies in getting the pace right. Selling government bonds removes liquidity permanently, but it also adds securities to a market already absorbing substantial government borrowing. Aggressive sales can push bond yields higher, increase borrowing costs and eventually feed into the price of credit for businesses and households. Removing liquidity too slowly carries the opposite danger: monetary conditions remain easier than intended and any future policy-rate action loses some of its force. The RBI therefore has to navigate between two undesirable outcomes—allowing excessive liquidity to blunt monetary policy or withdrawing it so quickly that financial conditions tighten unnecessarily. The strong demand for the first Rs 50,000-crore auction gives the central bank some room, but does not eliminate this balancing act.

The repo rate may attract the headlines, but its effectiveness ultimately depends on whether market rates respond to it. India does not need a sudden monetary squeeze; nor should abundant liquidity become a permanent subsidy to easy money. The RBI's task now is to drain the excess gradually, predictably and with enough flexibility to respond to changing credit demand, inflation and global financial conditions. Having supplied liquidity when the system required support, it must now demonstrate the equally important skill of withdrawing it without unsettling growth.

LETTER



letter2editor.mp@gmail.com.

Boardroom Questions

The dispute over the validity of the Tata Sons board resolution concerning N Chandrasekaran's reappointment highlights the importance of procedural clarity in corporate governance. For an institution of Tata's stature, differences between Tata Sons and Tata Trusts should be resolved transparently, within established governance frameworks, to preserve stakeholder confidence.

AMIT SHARMA,
DELHI

You can also send your comments to The Editor, Millennium Post, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002

CSR: Money Problem or Where Problem?

India has never had so much corporate money pumped into CSR work. Yet, the question is whether we are putting the funds where there is the greatest need

TALKING SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER IS A JOURNALIST & COMMUNICATIONS SPECIALIST

"Money isn't the same as impact."

— Anonymous

The numbers say it all: India spent a staggering Rs 40,794 crore on Corporate Social Responsibility projects in 2024-25. Much of this corporate money flowed into education, health-care, livelihoods, sanitation and other social causes. If we look closer, however, the geography of that spending is intriguing. For instance, per-person CSR spends work out to Rs 1,243 in Delhi, against just Rs 35 in Bihar.

The disparity in these numbers does not mean Delhi should get less or Bihar deserves more. After all, costs, projects and capacities differ. But they do beg an uncomfortable question: Is India deciding where CSR money should go by looking at the needs on the ground, or is it doing so by looking at where the money is available to be spent? Too often, we seem to be beginning the CSR journey with the money.

All large companies have a certain CSR budget. They iden-



The answer is not to make companies spend more. It is to make the money work harder

tify an implementing agency, choose an area or project to be pursued, and then attempt to connect the available resources with a pressing social need. That is a supply-led approach. And it is time to reverse the sequence.

Start with the Need

Imagine a company proudly inaugurating a 'Smart Classroom' in a school in a village. The photographs are wonderful: new computers, beaming children, executives, officials and perhaps a ribbon-cutting ceremony.

But what if the real problem in that village is not technology at all? What if 17-year-old girls are dropping out because there is no safe transport to school? Or because the toilet doesn't work? Or because they are needed at home?

The smart classroom may be a perfectly good project. It may simply not be the most urgent one. That is the distinction CSR needs to confront. The intervention should follow the diagnosis, not the other way around.

The evidence suggests that the gap is real. CRISIL found that in FY 2024-25, only 397 of 2,020

THE CSR KITTY IS OVERFLOWING, BUT THE MONEY SHOULD TACKLE THE PROBLEMS THAT MATTER MOST

qualifying listed companies undertook CSR projects in India's aspirational districts. Their combined spend was Rs 2,390 crore, just 12 per cent of total CSR spending. That is not proof that CSR money is being badly spent. But it is reason enough to ask whether the country's most difficult development problems are getting their proportionate share of corporate attention.

Know the People

The problem becomes even clearer when we stop talking about categories and start talking about people. Women. Farmers. Children. Rural communities. Yes, these are conve-

nient CSR labels. But real life is often messier.

A farmer may not need a training workshop on modern agriculture; he may need irrigation, a functioning market link or a road that allows him to reach that market. An elderly villager may not need a health-awareness camp; he may simply need a doctor within reach. A school may not need a new building; it may need teachers who turn up, girls who stay on and children who can actually read at the appropriate age.

This is why needs assessment matters. The first question should not be: "What can we fund?" It should be: "What is preventing this community from moving forward?" Only then should the cheque book come out.

The Visibility Trap

There is another uncomfortable reality. Some CSR interventions are simply easier to display than others. A school building has a plaque. A hospital wing has an inauguration. A scholarship programme produces photographs. A large community event

produces a crowd. But preventing a girl from dropping out does not necessarily produce any of these. Nor does spending months helping a family obtain a livelihood, getting a bedridden elderly person to a doctor, or ensuring that a health scheme actually reaches the person who needs it.

None of this means companies are acting cynically. Good intentions can coexist with a system that rewards what is visible, measurable and easy to communicate. But if the easiest project to execute—and take a bow for—is not necessarily the most important problem to solve, CSR needs a different compass. It needs to begin somewhere else.

Follow the Need

The answer is not to make companies spend more. It is to make the money work harder. A company may have the money. An NGO may know the village. A government department may already have the scheme. The missing ingredient may simply be putting the three together. And the opening question should always be the same: What is actually missing here?

Because Rs 40,794 crore is no longer a token gesture. It is enough money to make the question of allocation impossible to ignore. If corporate giving continues to gravitate towards places with easy access, established partners, visible projects and convenient ceremonies, we may end up with an impressive map of CSR activity without a corresponding map of the country's greatest needs.

The real test is not how many projects were launched, beneficiaries counted or photographs taken. It is whether the money travelled far enough from the boardroom to find the problem nobody had thought worth photographing. India may not have a CSR money problem anymore. It has a CSR "where" problem.

Views expressed are personal

Bangladesh's New Security Dilemma

Makkah pact debate will test Dhaka's traditional approach to alliances and regional diplomacy

STRATEGIC COMPASS



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS A RETIRED IPS OFFICER, ADVISER NATSTRAT

In the wake of the recent Defence Pact signed between Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye, speculation is rife in Bangladesh over whether it will opt to formally align with these three countries in what is generally perceived to be an Islamic NATO, with Islam as the common religion.

Rahman's State Minister for Foreign Affairs, Humayun Kabir, told the media recently that the government held a "very positive" view of the Makkah pact, explicitly linking it to Bangladesh's plans to strengthen ties with "Muslim-majority nations." The briefing marked the first time a sitting Bangladeshi official had formally evinced interest in joining the Makkah alliance. However, if Bangladesh were to align formally with these three countries, its diplomatic, security and economic relationship with India would undergo a fundamental structural shift. Such

a realignment could naturally prompt accelerated thinking in New Delhi over the prospect of strategic encirclement, particularly as Rahman simultaneously pivots towards China. During a June visit to Beijing, he had called China Bangladesh's "most valued and trusted partner."

According to fresh inputs emanating from Bangladesh, the trilateral Makkah Defence Pact has set off an intense debate in Bangladesh—and, predictably, across the border. Speculation over whether Bangladesh should eventually join this security alliance has spilt into Parliament, social media and foreign-policy circles across the political spectrum. According to Dr Anas Ansar, who is an assistant professor in the Department of Political Science and Sociology at North South University (NSU), Bangladesh, and a senior researcher at the Arnold Bergstraesser Institute, University of Freiburg, Germany, Bangladesh does not appear to have a comprehensive National Security Strategy that clearly identifies the country's principal security threats, establishes priorities, defines the roles of different state institutions and explains how different traditional and non-traditional security apparatuses should work together.

The researcher further argues that those advocating Bangladesh's participation in the Makkah Pact have yet to adequately explain what concrete security problem the arrangement would solve for Bangladesh. Who are the potential adversaries? What obligations would membership create? What would Bangladesh contribute, and what would it receive in return? Most importantly, how would membership



Dhaka's move could alter its regional diplomatic balance

DHAKA MUST WEIGH PARTNERSHIPS WITHOUT SURRENDERING ROOM FOR STRATEGIC MANOEUVRE

fit into a broader national security strategy? But opponents of participation are not necessarily asking the right questions either. Their principal argument often rests on Bangladesh's longstanding preference for strategic autonomy, non-alignment and balanced relations with major powers.

The deeper problem seems to be that Bangladesh is debating a possible alliance without first having a serious national conversation about its own security doctrine. What are Bangladesh's principal security threats and strategic objectives? What are its red lines? Which partnerships strengthen its capabilities, and which risk creating new depen-

dencies? How should diplomacy, intelligence, economic resilience and military power work together to advance the national interest?

According to Ambassador (Retired) Tariq Karim, a former diplomat who was also High Commissioner of Bangladesh to India and is currently Adviser to the School of Liberal Arts and Social Sciences and the Bay of Bengal Studies Centre at Independent University, Bangladesh, the Makkah agreement raises an immediate question: why was a new pact necessary when Pakistan and Saudi Arabia already have a longstanding defence relationship? The three partners bring different strengths and vulnerabilities. Saudi Arabia is the wealthiest of the three and can finance defence and strategic investment. Yet its oil-dependent economy and energy infrastructure remain exposed, and its armed forces are relatively small. Türkiye, by contrast, has one of NATO's largest standing armies and an advanced defence-industrial base. But NATO membership may not protect it in a confrontation involving Israel. Ankara, therefore, has reason to seek additional deterrence

outside the traditional alliance structure. If Iran emerges as the region's major power, Bangladesh will need constructive ties with Tehran. If Türkiye, Saudi Arabia and Pakistan shape a parallel security bloc, Bangladesh will also need working relations with them. For Bangladesh, the lesson is cautionary, as per Tariq Karim, with the regional picture continuing to be kaleidoscopically fluid and its final shape still highly unpredictable.

Bangladesh's best option is to keep all doors open, maintain good bilateral relations with all sides, and avoid any arrangement that could place Bangladesh on the wrong side of history. Such a mistake would be strategically costly and would worsen socio-economic pressures at home. Bangladesh's safest course is strategic autonomy and active neutrality: not joining either side when partners are in conflict, while continuing to engage constructively with all to safeguard its own national interest. Bangladesh has signalled that it is open to joining the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement, as Dhaka seeks to expand its strategic partnerships.

Also, separately and collectively, Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye continue to send overtures to Bangladesh to join the pact, ostensibly to strengthen their fraternity. India, on its part, is watching the pros and cons for its eastern neighbour, Bangladesh, if it joins the pact at all. Whatever the case, strategists feel that it is not going to affect India's security interests because of India's already robust ties with the Islamic world in general. In this light, Bangladesh, at best, will only have a psychological advantage if it joins the pact.

Views expressed are personal

News at a glance

Indian-German climber dies in Manaslu avalanche

KATHMANDU: An Indian-German climber and his Nepali Sherpa guide have died after an avalanche struck their tent at Camp 3 of Mount Manaslu, the world's eighth-highest peak, a company official said on Sunday.

Dhruva Jyoti Guha and Fursemba Sherpa had advanced towards a higher camp from Camp 2 despite adverse weather conditions and were caught in the avalanche on Saturday night, said Mohan Lamsal, managing director of Makalu Adventure, which organised the expedition.

Russia wraps up 1st wartime parliamentary election

MOSCOW: Russia's first wartime parliamentary election was due to end Sunday, virtually devoid of opposition to President Vladimir Putin's policies and all but certain to cement the Kremlin's dominance. The last day of the election came as Ukrainian forces fired more than 1,000 drones at Russia overnight, including hundreds that were launched toward Moscow.

The vote began Friday, and authorities encouraged online balloting to boost turnout among its 111 million eligible voters.

Israeli man critically wounded in West Bank shooting

DUBAI: An Israeli man was critically wounded in a shooting attack in the West Bank, and the Israeli military conducted a widespread raid in the northern part of the occupied territory, officials said Sunday.

Meanwhile, Egypt, Jordan and Kuwait condemned Iranian-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen after they fired a ballistic missile at the Saudi capital on Saturday. A 30-year-old man was critically wounded in a shooting attack in the northern West Bank on Sunday morning.



Thaung Aye, newly elected Vice-chairman of the Union Solidarity and Development Party (USDP), leaves after the party's conference at Party Headquarters in Naypyitaw on Sunday

AP/PTI

Briefs

Pak: Imran Khan's sister detained

ISLAMABAD: Pakistani authorities on Sunday detained Aleema Khan, the sister of jailed former prime minister Imran Khan, ahead of a planned protest by his party next week.

Aleema was detained in Lahore and transferred to Kot Lakhpat jail, according to sources. She has been advocating for 73-year-old Khan's release from jail. He has been incarcerated since 2023.

Aleema was detained under the Punjab Maintenance of Public Order Ordinance, 1960, which allows local police to arrest anyone perceived as a threat to public peace.

Pak minister Naqvi to visit Tehran

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi will visit Tehran on Sunday for talks with Iranian leaders and officials amid escalated tension in West Asia, which involve the US-Iran conflict and fighting between Saudi Arabia and Yemen's Houthis, according to media reports.

Iranian foreign ministry spokesperson Esmaeil Baghaei said Naqvi's visit would focus on bilateral relations and follow-up to previous understandings between the two countries, with no specific mediation message planned, Iranian state broadcaster IRIB reported on Saturday.

"The visit of Pakistan's interior minister is entirely within the framework of bilateral discussions," Baghaei was quoted.

AMERICAN EMBASSIES ISSUE SECURITY ALERTS

US fears rapid escalation in West Asia after Houthis attack Riyadh

AGENCIES

Riyadh, September 20

Smoke rose near King Khalid International Airport in Riyadh after Yemen's Houthi rebels launched a large-scale attack on Saudi Arabia on Saturday.

Two explosions were heard in the capital, while some flights were delayed.

The Houthis said they targeted "sensitive targets" in Riyadh and a Saudi Aramco facility in Yanbu.

The group said it used ballistic and cruise missiles and drones in the attacks.

Qatar's Foreign Ministry has strongly condemned the ballistic missile strike launched by the Houthis directed at Riyadh, alongside the targeting of civilian populations and vital civilian infrastructure across Bish, Taif, Farasan, and Yanbu. Within an official statement, the ministry characterised these assaults as a "blatant violation" of Saudi Arabia's sovereignty alongside a clear breach of international law, while conveying its "full solidarity" with the kingdom alongside its backing for every legitimate measure undertaken to safeguard national security and interests. US embassies across the Middle East have issued security alerts



Representational Image

warning Americans to maintain "heightened vigilance" following attacks by Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthi rebels on Saudi Arabia.

Embassies in Bahrain, Israel, Iraq, Jordan,

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Two explosions were heard in Riyadh, while some flights were delayed
- » Houthis said it used ballistic and cruise missiles & drones in attacks
- » Embassies in Bahrain, Israel, Iraq, Jordan, Kuwait, Lebanon, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE on alert

Kuwait, Lebanon, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE said the "military conflict has the potential to escalate rapidly" and that the security environment remained "complex."

The alerts also advised people to "be aware of potential flight cancellations, airspace closures, and travel disruptions."

It comes after the Houthi rebels on Saturday said they had carried out two operations using ballistic and cruise missiles as well as drones to target Saudi Arabia in response to Saudi attacks.

Yemen's Houthi rebels, who declared a naval blockade of Saudi Arabia in July, have been launching increasing attacks on Saudi cities and shipping, further heightening tensions in the Middle East.

Saudi Arabia has hit back with its own strikes on the group - which has seized vast stretches of territory in Yemen this month in a lightning offensive - but has failed to stop its advance.

In a press briefing on Friday, Stéphane Dujarric, a spokesperson for the UN Secretary-General, addressed the situation in Yemen.

"Since hostilities escalated in August, the Human Rights office has documented 110 civilian casualties in 31 incidents, including 28 killed and 82 injured, across Taizz, Al Hudaydah and Marib. Insecurity and access constraints continue to hamper our ability to verify the actual number as you can imagine is very likely higher," Dujarric said

Ukraine fires over 1,000 drones at Russia

Moscow's mayor described it as the 'largest ever' attack



ASSOCIATED PRESS

Moscow, September 20

Ukrainian forces fired more than 1,000 drones at Russia overnight, including hundreds that were launched toward Moscow, officials said Sunday as the Kremlin was wrapping up the third and last day of its parliamentary elections.

Moscow's mayor described the wave of drones as the "largest ever" attack on the Russian capital and said there had been damage to a Moscow oil refinery and a residential building.

Across the wider Moscow region, the attack killed two people and wounded 20, local Gov.

Andrei Vorobyov said. The dead were a 74-year-old man and a 44-year-old woman, he said.

Writing on social media, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said that Kyiv had used a range of missiles and drones in the attack -- including Ukraine's domestically made Flamingo and Pelican missiles -- to hit oil and logistics facilities.

"These are billions of dollars that sustain the war machine," Zelenskyy said, referring to the financial pressure that Kyiv hopes to put on Russia's economy.

The voting underway in Russia is the country's first wartime parliamentary election.

North Korea launches two ballistic missiles toward sea

Bid to escalate pressure on the United States

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Seoul, September 20

North Korea launched two short-range ballistic missiles toward the sea on Sunday, South Korea's military said, days after the North threatened to bolster its nuclear deterrent capabilities and respond to what it called US hostilities.

The launches were the latest in a series of weapons demonstrations by North Korea even after US President Donald Trump scaled back a joint military exercise with South Korea last month in an apparent effort to revive diplomacy



A TV screen shows a file image of a North Korean missile launch during a news program at Seoul Railway Station in Seoul, on Sunday

AP/PTI

with the North's leader, Kim Jong Un.

The two missile launches -- about three

hours apart -- were conducted from North Korea's eastern coastal Wonsan area.

B'desh PM to highlight Rohingya, climate issues in UNGA address

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

Dhaka, September 20

Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman is set to deliver his maiden UN General Assembly address in Bangla on September 24, highlighting the Rohingya crisis, climate change and his government's democratic agenda, according to a media report. Rahman will leave Dhaka for New York on September 21 and is scheduled to return on September 25, the state-owned BSS news agency reported on Sunday.

His visit will mark his first participation in the

RAHMAN WILL LEAVE DHAKA FOR NEW YORK TODAY AND IS SCHEDULED TO RETURN ON SEP 25

UN General Assembly as prime minister and the first UNGA appearance of the incumbent Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) government, which came to power in February. On the sidelines of the UNGA, Rahman is scheduled to hold bilateral meetings with the Crown Prince of Kuwait and the prime ministers

of Croatia, Bhutan, Thailand, Pakistan and Haiti, according to BSS.

The talks are expected to cover political and economic relations, trade and investment, development cooperation, the Rohingya crisis and other issues of mutual interest, the report said.

At the UNGA, Rahman will also outline Bangladesh's positions on global peace and security, sustainable development, economic cooperation and reform of the multilateral system. Foreign Secretary Asad Alam Siam said at a press conference on Sunday.

Fast food from US, China catches on in both nations

The Kentucky-born fried chicken chain counts about 13,000 restaurants in China

ASSOCIATED PRESS

New York, September 20

China and the United States are divided on many issues, from tariffs and technology to Taiwan. But there is one thing tying them together: fast food. American restaurant and beverage chains are expanding rapidly in China, drawn by the potential customer pool in a country with four times the US population. China's languishing economy and cutthroat industry

competition, meanwhile, have Chinese chains trying their luck in the US, turning crumbs and straws into a two-way cultural bridge between the two superpowers.

The bilateral trade in burgers and bubble tea is business- and consumer-led gastrodiploacy in action, said Yaling Jiang, the founder of ApertureChina, a market research company with headquarters in Shanghai and London. In China, recent Ameri-

KEY POINTS

- » American restaurant and beverage chains are expanding rapidly in China
- » the increasingly international palates of Americans have created space for Chinese brands to serve as their nation's envoys

can arrivals like Popeyes

and Five Guys are seen as a guilty pleasure, she said, while the increasingly international palates of Americans have created space for Chinese brands to serve as their nation's unofficial ambassadors.

"Consumerism builds a safe, introductory channel for contemporary Chinese culture and can be a great way to elevate China's soft power," Jiang said. The White House has not revealed the menu for the state dinner

that US President Donald Trump is hosting for Chinese President Xi Jinping on Thursday. But a taste for a cheap, crowd-pleasing meal may be something the two leaders share.

In 2013, Xi made a rare public visit to a steamed-bun restaurant in Beijing. He waited in line and ordered a 21-yuan (\$3) meal featuring six pork-and-scalion buns, vegetables, and a bowl of stewed pork liver and intestines.

Macron, Carney to meet in French Atlantic archipelago

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Paris, September 20

French President Emmanuel Macron and Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney are set to meet Sunday to deepen economic and security ties on the remote North Atlantic archipelago of Saint-Pierre-et-Miquelon.

The meeting comes days after Carney embraced the prospect of Canada becoming the European Union's first

TALKS WILL ALLOW US ... TO STRENGTHEN OUR BILATERAL ECONOMIC TIES & DEFENCE TIES

associate member, saying closer ties with the continent would ensure no country could control Canada's markets or undermine its sovereignty.

US President Donald

Trump's tariffs, demands for economic concessions and repeated talk of making Canada the 51st state have pushed Ottawa to reduce its dependence on its neighbour and pursue deeper economic, security and political relationships with Europe. "This is an important moment," Macron said upon arriving Saturday in the French territory off the coast of Newfoundland, Canada.

EXPORTS TO 4 BRICS NATIONS WAS \$14.9 BN IN APRIL-AUG FY26

India’s exports to core BRICS mkts rise 34% to \$19.9 bn in April-August

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 20

India’s exports to China, South Africa, Brazil and Russia grew 34 per cent to \$19.9 billion in April-August FY27, led by a 39 per cent jump in shipments to China, highlighting the growing importance of the BRICS bloc for India’s export growth.

“As India deepens its engagement with the BRICS bloc, strongest momentum is coming from the BRICS members, especially Core BRICS founding partners – China, South Africa, Brazil, and Russia,” an official said.

According to the commerce ministry data, exports to the four core BRICS economies grew by 34 per cent, rising from \$14.9 billion in April-August 2025-26 to \$19.9 billion in April-August 2026-27.

The share of the four countries in India’s total exports increased to 9.2 per cent during the first five months of this fiscal from 8.1 per cent in the same period of 2025-26.



Among the core BRICS countries, China emerged as the largest contributor, with Indian exports expanding by 39 per cent to reach \$9.6 billion in the first five months of 2026-27.

At the same time, South Africa recorded the fastest growth rate, with exports surging 58 per cent during the period. Brazil and Russia also maintained steady double-digit growth of 13 per cent and 11 per cent.

“India is not only strengthening its trade footprint within BRICS but is also becoming more integrated with the bloc’s

largest economies. With exports to Core BRICS growing nearly three times faster than exports to the broader BRICS grouping, these markets are increasingly emerging as a key pillar of India’s export strategy,” the commerce ministry official said.

INDIA’S EXPORTS TO JAPAN, ITALY AND S KOREA

During April-August 2026-27, India’s exports to Japan surged to \$3.43 billion, registering a 43 per cent growth over the same period last fiscal.

India is steadily expand-

KEY POINTS

» The share of the four countries in India’s total exports increased to 9.2 per cent during the first five months of FY27 from 8.1 per cent in the same period of FY26

» ‘India is not only strengthening its trade footprint within BRICS but is also becoming more integrated with the bloc’s largest economies,’ a commerce ministry official said

the five months of 2026-27, rising to \$3.92 billion from \$3.02 billion in April-August 2025-26, reflecting a growth of about 30 per cent. On the other hand, outbound shipments to South Korea grew 22 per cent to \$3.21 billion.

The growth story is being driven by India’s increasing role as a supplier of industrial raw materials, energy products, and intermediate goods that feed into South Korea’s advanced manufacturing ecosystem.

The main sectors that helped push exports to South Korea included minerals, fuels, electronics, aluminium, iron and steel and chemicals.

As South Korea strengthens its position as a global hub for automobiles, electronics, semiconductors, and advanced manufacturing, India is increasingly becoming a preferred sourcing partner, driving sustained growth in bilateral trade and reinforcing economic ties between the two nations, the official said.

AGENCIES

Guwahati, September 20

Adani Power’s 3,200 MW ultra-supercritical thermal power project in Assam represents an investment of Rs 48,000 crore and is slated to become the largest power generation asset in the Northeast, Adani Group Director Jeet Adani said on Sunday.

Speaking at the foundation stone-laying ceremony of the project at Chapar in lower Assam’s Dhubri district, he said the project would support industrial and business activity in the region while providing affordable electricity to households.

“The upcoming 3,200 MW Thermal Power Project by Adani Power represents an investment of Rs 48,000 Crore. In just a few years, this project will become the largest power generation asset in the Northeast. It will fuel industries, give businesses the power to scale, and help bring affordable electricity to homes,” he said.

“Building this project will bring together thousands of workers, engineers, technicians, contractors, and suppliers. It will spark massive economic activity for local



Adani Group Director Jeet Adani

businesses. The youth will find excellent jobs close to home, and the communities living around the project will be our partners in this progress. In fact, we’ve already conducted 4 to 5 job drives here, and 4,500 local youth from Assam have already been hired,” he added.

Jeet Adani said the Group’s businesses in Assam will generate around 40,000 direct and indirect job opportunities for the people here.

“This is just the beginning. As we grow in Assam, opportunities for local youth will grow with us. Our goal is to ensure that more and more local talent becomes an active part of this growth journey,” he said.

He said Assam’s true identity lies in the warmth of its people and their incredible willpower.

“Over the last few years, we’ve witnessed a huge shift across the entire Northeast. This region has always been famous for its stunning beauty and rich culture. But today, its identity has evolved way beyond that. Today, alongside its culture, the Northeast is emerging as a dynamic new powerhouse of economic growth, modern infrastructure and national mega-projects. And as the gateway to the Northeast, Assam is leading this change,” he said.

He said under visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, the state has risen to become one of India’s most promising investment destinations.

Jeet Adani said the Assam Chief Minister want to see development on the ground, as fast as possible. There is speed in his decisions, a real sense of urgency in his execution, and an incredible enthusiasm towards new ideas.

He keeps an eye on the progress, timeline and delivery of every single project. And it is this exact combination that is supercharging the speed of Assam’s development,” Jeet Adani said.

DPIIT to organise workshop for industry on FTAs on September 22

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, September 20

The Department for Promotion of Industry & Internal Trade (DPIIT) will organise a day-long workshop on Tuesday for stakeholders to discuss ease of doing business initiatives, FTAs opportunities & ongoing reforms aimed at simplifying and streamlining trade-related processes and procedures, an official said.

The workshop will be held on September 22 under the chairmanship of Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal. The industry official said the session will focus on an overview of FTAs, ease of doing business and regulatory compliance initiatives.

Suggestions will be sought from industry associations and export promotion councils on ground-level implementation challenges and procedural bottlenecks.

The Department of Commerce has already held a similar workshop to increase awareness about FTAs finalised by India.

India has implemented such pacts with countries including the UK, Oman, EFTA bloc, Australia & the UAE. A trade pact with New Zealand will come into force from next month & the India-EU FTA is likely to be signed by December.

‘NMDC looking to achieve 60 MT iron ore output in current fiscal’

AGENCIES

New Delhi, September 20

NMDC is working on strategies to raise iron ore production to 60 MT this fiscal to meet growing domestic steel demand, Chairman Amitava Mukherjee said.

India’s largest iron ore producer crossed the 50 MT mark in FY26 and is now executing a production ramp-up plan to reach 60 MTPA from existing mines, along with assets of NMDC-CMDC Ltd (NCL), representing around 20 per cent year-on-year growth.

Aligned with the National Steel Policy 2017, which targets 300 MT of installed domestic steel-

IT PLANS TO START COMMERCIAL THERMAL COAL OUTPUT IN Q3 FY27, SELL AROUND 1 MT DURING THE YEAR

making capacity by 2030-31, NMDC aims to scale iron ore output to 100 MT by then. “We are progressing well. We are on track, and will definitely achieve it,” Mukherjee said on the 100 MT target.

The company has applied for environmental clearances for some deposits, while mine infrastructure is being developed at several locations. Bids

have also been invited for infrastructure such as belt conveyors, crushers and breakers to enhance existing mine capacity.

NMDC operates four mechanised iron ore mining complexes in Chhattisgarh and Karnataka and meets around 20 per cent of India’s iron ore requirement.

It plans to start commercial thermal coal production in Q3 FY27 and sell around 1 MT during the year. A coking coal mine is also being developed, with production targeted from FY28. By 2030, NMDC aims to derive at least 20 per cent of revenue from minerals other than iron ore.

ANI NEWS

New Delhi, September 20

Adani Group is developing an aero-city near the new Guwahati airport terminal and plans to take up pumped storage, cement and maintenance, repair and overhaul (MRO) projects in Assam, Jeet Adani, Director, Adani Airport Holdings, said on Sunday.

Speaking on the sidelines of the foundation stone-laying event of Adani Power Ltd’s 3,200 MW ultra-supercritical thermal power plant at Chapar in Dhubri district, Jeet Adani said the group currently has three major projects in the state, apart from



two cement projects and an MRO project that are in the pipeline.

“Right in front of (the new Guwahati Terminal), we are developing an aero-city. Then, a thermal power project is coming; a PSP project is coming. So, right now, we have three big projects. And two cement projects are coming. And we are also starting an MRO project,” he said.

Tata Trusts challenges Chandrasekaran’s reappointment

ANI NEWS

New Delhi, September 20

The resolution to reappoint N Chandrasekaran as Chairman of Tata Sons was not validly passed at the company’s September 17 board meeting as the mandatory support of Tata Trusts’ nominee directors was not secured, Tata Trusts said on Sunday.

According to Tata Trusts, Tata Sons’ Articles of Association (AoA) require the affirmative support of a majority of directors nominated by Tata Trusts, which hold approximately 66 per cent of the company.

With two Tata Trusts nominees on the board, both directors would have to support the resolution for the separate condition under the Articles of Association to be met.

One of the two nominees voted against the resolution on September 17, meaning the required affirmative support was not available, the Trusts said.

The Trusts further said the Chairman’s casting vote cannot be used to overcome the failure of this condition, as such a vote is available only in case of equality of votes at the overall board



level and does not apply to the requirement concerning Tata Trusts’ nominee directors.

“There was no paralysis and there was no deadlock. The Board put a question, and the AoA answered it in the negative,” the Trusts said.

The Trusts also referred

to the Supreme Court proceedings arising from the removal of former Tata Sons chairman Cyrus Mistry, arguing that Tata Sons had previously defended the affirmative voting rights of Trusts’ nominee directors under Articles 104B and 121.

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) had held these rights to be oppressive, but the Supreme Court accepted Tata Sons’ position and set aside that finding, according to the release.

The Trusts said Tata Sons therefore could not

now disregard protections that it had previously defended before the Supreme Court.

The release also rejected the argument that listing Tata Sons would be necessary to strengthen its corporate governance, pointing to existing provisions covering independent directors, audit and nomination committees, related-party transactions, retirement of directors by rotation and insider trading.

The Trusts said these governance standards had been adopted voluntarily by Tata Sons before the current issue arose.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



Bank of Baroda on Saturday opened its new Nahan branch in Himachal Pradesh’s Sirmour district, taking its state branch network to 38, in presence of MP Suresh Kashyap and senior bank officials.

NSE shareholders retain significant stake even after selling shares in OFS

Selling shareholders, mainly institutional investors, held 36.82% stake in NSE before IPO & tendered shares representing a 5.11% stake

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, September 20

A majority of the existing shareholders of the National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) have retained a significant portion of their holdings even after tendering shares in the offer-for-sale (OFS) component of the exchange’s Rs 22,569-crore initial public offering (IPO).

The selling shareholders largely comprised institutional investors, who collectively held a 36.82 per cent

stake in NSE before the IPO and tendered shares representing a 5.11 per cent stake in the exchange, according to an analysis of data.

Of the 20 institutional shareholders that participated in the OFS, nine were foreign institutional investors, which collectively held a 15.96 per cent stake before the IPO, it added.

The remaining 11 were domestic institutions, comprising 10 public sector entities and ICICI Lombard General Insurance, which together held a 20.86 per



cent stake before the OFS.

Several large institutional shareholders have largely stayed put despite participating in the OFS.

Aranda Investments, which held a 4.54 per

CLOSER LOOK

» Of the 20 institutional shareholders that participated in the OFS, nine were foreign institutional investors, which collectively held a 15.96 per cent stake before the IPO

» Among other large foreign investors, Crown Capital offered around 11 per cent of its pre-OFS holding, while TA Asia Pacific reduced its holding by about 6 per cent

cent stake before the OFS, Stock Holding Corporation of India with a 4.44 per cent stake, SBI Capital Markets with 4.33 per cent and ChrysCapital with 3.73 per cent have reduced their

holdings by an average of only around 7 per cent.

Among other large foreign investors, Crown Capital offered around 11 per cent of its pre-OFS holding, while TA Asia Pacific

reduced its holding by about 6 per cent.

The pattern indicates that the OFS has allowed existing investors to partially monetise their investments while continuing to hold substantial stakes in NSE.

The IPO, which was fully subscribed on the second day of bidding on Friday, is India’s second-largest public issue after Hyundai Motor India’s Rs 27,870-crore IPO in 2024. It has also surpassed the Rs 21,000-crore public offer of

Life Insurance Corporation of India in 2022.

The issue has drawn strong investor interest, with non-institutional investors and qualified institutional buyers driving subscription on the second day of bidding.

The IPO comprises an OFS of up to 12.64 crore equity shares by existing shareholders. The exchange has fixed a price band of Rs 1,700-1,785 per share, valuing NSE at up to Rs 4.42 lakh crore at the upper end of the price band. Since the

issue is entirely an OFS, the proceeds from the share sale will accrue to existing shareholders and not to NSE.

The size of the OFS was earlier planned at 14.9 crore shares, but was subsequently reduced to 12.64 crore shares, bringing down the overall issue size from the initial estimate of around Rs 30,000 crore.

The IPO will close on September 21, while NSE shares are expected to make their market debut on September 24.

PRICE SUPPORT FOR AT LEAST 10 YEARS

Govt rolls out GOBARdhan rules, assures up to 100% CBG offtake

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 20

The government has operationalised its Rs 23,731-crore GOBARdhan scheme for compressed biogas (CBG), offering producers assured offtake of up to 100 per cent of their output, a government-backed administered price for at least 10 years and capital assistance, in a bid to make waste-to-energy projects more commercially viable and attract private investment.

The Petroleum and Natural Gas Ministry, in operational guidelines dated September 15, has laid down detailed mechanisms for the scheme, which will run from 2026-27 to 2035-36 and seeks to establish a more predictable market for CBG producers.

GOBARdhan stands for Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan. It is the government's programme to turn organic waste such as cattle dung, agricultural residue, food waste and other biomass into useful products such as biogas, CBG and organic



manure. This is to be commingled with natural gas for supply to users.

The scheme brings together six components – assured CBG offtake, a pricing framework, capital assistance, pipeline infrastructure, credit guarantee support and a CBG ecosystem challenge fund, according to the MoPNG guidelines. The move addresses some of the key hurdles that have constrained the scaling up of India's CBG industry, particularly uncertainty over long-term buyers and project revenues. The government has said the broader

scheme is aimed at nearly ten-fold growth in domestic CBG production and greater private investment in the sector.

Under the new framework, eligible CBG producers can opt for assured offtake of up to 100 per cent of CBG available for sale, subject to technical and operational feasibility. The gas will be mapped either to City Gas Distribution (CGD) entities and geographical areas or to identified CBG clusters for aggregation and injection into trunk pipelines.

City gas distributors will also be required to procure

KEY POINTS

- » The scheme has six components — assured CBG offtake, a pricing framework, capital assistance, pipeline infrastructure, credit guarantee support & CBG ecosystem challenge fund
- » The govt has also introduced an administered CBG price of Rs 2,110 per MMBtu, excluding taxes and compression charges

and sell CBG within their overall gas supplies for the CNG transport and domestic PNG segments, according to a phased obligation of 3 per cent in FY27, 4 per cent in FY28 and 5 per cent from FY29 onwards, it said.

The assured-offtake mechanism is intended to address a longstanding problem for CBG developers: having a plant does not by itself guarantee a buyer for the gas.

Under the new rules, firm offtake through the CGD route will be governed by tripartite agreements involving the producer, the CGD entity and GAIL

as the designated synchro operator. Trunk-pipeline offtake will also be based only on firm contractual arrangements.

The framework goes beyond a demand mandate by prescribing consequences for non-compliance. If a CGD entity fails to execute a firm offtake agreement within the stipulated period, the ministry may consider measures including rationalisation of its APM/non-APM gas allocation equivalent to the requested CBG quantity.

The government has also introduced an administered CBG price of Rs 2,110 per million British thermal unit (MMBtu), equivalent to about Rs 98 per kg at 95 per cent methane content, excluding taxes and compression charges.

The price will remain in place for a minimum of 10 years, until March 31, 2036, although it can be revised prospectively based on factors including CBG production economics, inflation and other considerations determined by the Project Approval Board.

‘India’s semiconductor push aims chips for cars, TVs & power infra’

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 20

India wants its semiconductor capabilities to reach into everyday products such as cars, televisions and refrigerators, as well as critical power infrastructure in the coming years, Electronics and IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw has said, outlining the sheer breadth of chip-making prowess the country aims to build going forward.

The minister's vision comes as India steps up efforts to establish a larger presence in the global semiconductor value chain, with the government seeking to move beyond chip assembly and testing, and build capabilities spanning design, fabrication, equipment and materials. Under the second phase of the semiconductor programme, the government has committed Rs 1.27 lakh crore to expand the domestic ecosystem and attract global investments.

The government recently said it received about Rs 1 lakh crore in investor interest under the second phase of the semiconductor scheme, and this week saw a slew of big-ticket announcements, including Applied



Electronics and IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw

Materials' \$5-billion India plan through 2035, Lam Research's proposed Rs 10,000-crore investment, Tata Electronics' 363-acre vendor park at Dholera and Fujifilm's Rs 800-crore semiconductor materials plant.

Vaishnaw said India should be designing and manufacturing chips for cars, power systems, televisions, refrigerators and other appliances within the next five years.

"There are many chips which go in automobiles, in cars, scooters and motorcycles, that are manufactured in our country. We should be able to have many of those chips designed and manufactured in India," Vaishnaw said.

The minister said a similar capability should be developed in the power sector, including chips used in transmission

lines, transformers and converters.

"There are many chips which go into power sector, for example, the transmission lines, the transformers and the converters. We should be able to manufacture many of those chips, which are designed and made in India," he said.

In the consumer electronics space, Vaishnaw said, many of the chips used in televisions, refrigerators and other household appliances should also be designed and manufactured in India.

"...we don't really see the chip; we see the finished product. When we buy a TV, we don't see the chip inside it, but it is the chip which is driving the entire thing," he said, describing the semiconductor as the "brain" and "heart" of a television.

"So once we move in that direction, it will be very good," he added.

Vaishnaw cited a display-control module plant coming up in Uttar Pradesh as an example of the capabilities India is seeking to build.

The module controls how a television displays the final picture and will be manufactured in the country, he said.

Titan open to acquire smaller watch brands, sees strong premium segment growth: Official

AGENCIES
Bengaluru, September 20

Leading watchmaker Titan is open to acquiring or investing in smaller and emerging watch brands as part of its growth strategy, a top company official said.

Titan Chief Marketing Officer Ranjani Krishnaswamy said the company expects a "robust" festive season, driven by healthy consumer demand & an early wedding season coinciding with delayed Diwali.

"We are looking at a very robust demand. We are seeing a very healthy start to the festive season," she said, adding that Titan was struggling to ensure capacity to service demand.

Krishnaswamy said Titan was evaluating acquisition opportunities complementary to its long-term growth ambitions, citing its jewellery acquisitions and overseas investments.

She said emerging Indian watch brands were positive for the category and encouraged greater innovation. Titan recently launched Vetra, a branded movement platform, to strengthen its high-end global horology presence.

Premium watches are growing nearly twice as fast as the sub-Rs 25,000 category, while the sub-Rs 1,000 segment faces "serious sluggishness".

India on track for 6.5-7% real GDP growth in current fiscal

ANI NEWS
New Delhi, September 20

India is on track to record real GDP growth of 6.5-7 per cent in the current fiscal, with nominal GDP growth expected at around 11-12 per cent, while corporate earnings growth could accelerate to 17 per cent next fiscal from 14 per cent, Jefferies said in a report.

India's structural growth story remains intact despite geopolitical challenges & elevated energy risks, with economic indicators showing greater resilience than expected, it said. According to the brokerage, the improvement in nominal GDP growth is expected to

support a pickup in earnings growth from 14 per cent in FY27 to 17 per cent in FY28.

Jefferies highlighted strong bank credit growth as a key indicator of the economy's momentum. Bank credit expanded 19.1 per cent year-on-year at the end of August, while corporate lending grew 21.6 per cent in July. Loans to MSMEs rose 24.9 per cent, supported by 17.8 per cent deposit growth in August.

The report said the pickup in SME lending could indicate that recent GST & labour reforms, along with efforts to improve the ease of doing business, are beginning to

generate benefits. The rise in corporate lending also points to a possible revival of the private-sector capital expenditure cycle.

Domestic demand has also remained firm. GST receipts increased 14.8 per cent y-o-y in August, while power demand growth jumped to 9.4 per cent during April-August from 1.8 per cent in January-March. Residential real estate sales across top seven cities rose 7 per cent y-o-y in the first seven months of 2026, against 1 per cent decline in 2025. Jefferies noted that India's outlook remains exposed to developments in the Middle East, particularly through energy prices.

Crude oil prices, situation in West Asia to drive market this week

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, September 20

Market investors would track any implications arising from US President Donald Trump signing the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act, with crude oil and geopolitical developments remaining the key driving trends for equities this week, analysts said.

Besides, trading activity of foreign investors and trends in global markets would also be tracked, they added.

"Indian equities enter



the coming week with crude oil, global bond yields and geopolitical developments likely to remain the main drivers of sentiment. A new source of uncertainty for Indian markets is emerging on the trade front.

"US President Donald Trump has signed into

law legislation giving his administration expanded powers to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on imports from major buyers of Russian oil and gas, with India among the countries potentially exposed given its significant purchases of Russian crude," Ponnudi R, CEO - Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex dropped 486.8 points, or 0.65 per cent, and the NSE Nifty dipped 51.7 points, or 0.22 per cent.

FPIs pull out ₹20,974 cr from equities so far in Sept

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, September 20

Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) have turned cautious again, pulling out Rs 20,974 crore from Indian equities so far in September amid global uncertainties, higher US interest rates and bond yields, elevated crude oil prices and a weakening rupee.

The latest outflow comes after foreign investors returned to Indian equities in July and August, when they invested Rs 20,200 crore and Rs 29,630 crore, respectively, according to data from CDSL.



With the September selling, foreign portfolio investors have now withdrawn a total of Rs 2.45 lakh crore from Indian equities so far in 2026, surpassing the Rs 1.66 lakh crore outflow recorded during the entire 2025.

According to the data, FPIs withdrew Rs 20,974 crore from Indian equities

this month, till September 18. However, the trend of FPI investment through the primary market has been continuing in the month.

Dheeraj Gaur, Chief Investment Strategy Officer at Choice Wealth, attributed the latest selling by FPIs to three key factors -- higher US interest rates and yields, elevated crude oil prices amid geopolitical tensions, and weakness in the Indian rupee.

The Federal Reserve has raised rates to 3.75-4.00 per cent, with the narrowing yield differential between India and the

US reducing the relative attractiveness of Indian assets.

At the same time, Brent crude has remained above \$100 a barrel, with escalating tensions in the Middle East adding to concerns over inflation and India's import bill, he said.

Foreign investors also extended their selling to the debt market during the period under review.

They withdrew Rs 10,296 crore through the Fully Accessible Route (FAR), Rs 1,817 crore via the Voluntary Retention Route (VRR) and Rs 1,068 crore through the general route.

Chip majors beeline at Semicon India to build wider ecosystem with local talent

Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said investment proposals worth \$12 bn are likely to come under the new scheme

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, September 20

Semicon India 2026 attracted huge participation from global semiconductor players looking to collaborate and expand their presence in India by leveraging skilled local talent and supportive central and state government policies.

Lithographic equipment major ASML, which has a presence only in semiconductor-producing nations, has set up an office in India and expressed optimism that more of its customers

are expected to enter India. ASML Chief Strategic Sourcing and Procurement Officer Allan Wayne said Tata Electronics is the first customer in India to have a 300-millimetre semiconductor fab with production capacity of 50,000 wafers per month.

"If we're going to be scaling this up, we need to be able to build many fabs here. This is why we are very confident in what we see here now with the policies coming from Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his team for the eco-



system and, of course, the great talent that we see in India," he said.

According to industry experts, no chip in the world gets produced without ASML equipment.

Wayne said ASML enters

CLOSER LOOK

- » ASML' Allan Wayne said Tata Electronics is the first customer in India to have a 300-millimetre semiconductor fab with production capacity of 50,000 wafers per month
- » 'As you go on into 2032, India's projection & ambition is to have between 15% & 25% of wafer fab of India's local semiconductor demand. That means you're going to have several fabs by 2032'

a region not only to support customers but to leverage talent.

"As you go on into 2032, India's projection and India's ambition is to have between 15 per cent and 25 per cent of the wafer fab of

India's local semiconductor demand. That means you're going to have several fabs by 2032," Wayne said.

The government has announced the Semicon 2.0 scheme with an incentive of around Rs 1.27 lakh crore

or \$13.5 billion to build the semiconductor ecosystem.

Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said investment proposals worth \$12 billion are likely to come under the new scheme for chip production.

Semiconductor gear maker Applied Materials committed an investment of \$5 billion, about Rs 48,000 crore, over the next 10 years at the event, a day after signing a pact with the Karnataka government to invest Rs 3,600 crore in research and development and production of equip-

ment that are used for manufacturing chips.

Applied Materials' competitor Lam Research announced an investment of Rs 10,000 crore to set up a silicon component manufacturing facility in India.

Around 56 memorandums of understanding were signed at the event.

Tata Electronics signed 16 agreements with vendors to support its Rs 1.18 lakh crore investment to set up a chip manufacturing unit in Dholera, Gujarat and a chip assembly and test unit in Assam. The company

announced the building of a 363-acre park in Dholera to house about 450 vendors that its plant will need.

The agreement brought depth to the semiconductor vendor ecosystem, ranging from partners supplying machines, materials, specialised gases, high-end logistics, etc with companies including Nexperia and BESI from Europe, JSR, Fujifilm, Sumitomo from Japan, Kelington from Malaysia, Ascendas First Space from Singapore, L&T Semiconductors, Inox Air Products, etc.

Briefs

Chess: India men beat Holland

SAMARKAND: Led by R Praggnanandhaa on the top board and world champion D Gukesh on the fourth, the Indian men scored an emphatic 3-1 victory over Holland but the Indian eves were shocked by Poland in the fifth round of the 46th chess Olympiad here.

Praggnanandhaa may have started with three draws against lower ranked players but when it mattered the most the Indian came up with a fine game to beat inform Anish Giri while Gukesh put it across Erwin L'Ami to score his fourth win in five games.

On the second board, Arjun Erigaaisi played out a draw with Jorden Van Foreest, while Nihal Sarin did not face many hurdles and drew with Loek Van Wely on the third.

India A beat Australia A

MULLANPUR: Tejal Hasabnis and Anushka Sharma made aggressive fifties while Nikki Prasad showcased her all-round skills as India A defeated Australia A by four wickets in the first women's one-dayer here on Sunday.

India, now, lead the three-match series 1-0 and the victory came as a relief for the hosts, who had lost the preceding T20 series 0-3.

Hasabnis, who hammered five fours and six sixes in her 82-ball 81, partnered promising Anushka Sharma (55, 61b, 6x4, 1x6) to add 126 runs for a crucial fourth wicket stand.

It helped India go past the 236-run target in 41.1 overs. However, the home side had a shaky beginning to their chase after slumping to 46 for three in 9.1 overs.

In that phase they lost openers Tanisha Singh, Priya Punia and skipper Yastika Bhatia to pacers Tess Flintoff, Milly Illingworth and leg-spinner Frankie Nicklin.

INDIAN BOXERS HANDED TRICKY DRAWS

Lovlina and Narender get QF starts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Nishio, September 20

Indian boxers were handed challenging draws on Sunday even as Lovlina Borgohain and Narender Berwal begin their campaigns in the quarterfinals.

The record-breaking performance at the recent Commonwealth Games has raised expectations around the Indian contingent, but the challenge at the Asian Games is a lot tougher.

The Asian Games features six men's and five women's weight categories. India had won four medals, including one silver and three bronze, in the previous edition.

Tokyo Olympic medalist Lovlina, who won silver in the 2023 edition, is one win away from a medal in the 75kg category, which features only eight boxers.

She opens the campaign against South Korea's Suyeon Seong and could then face reigning 70kg world champion Natalya Bogdanova of Kazakhstan or Uzbekistan's world bronze medallist Aziza Zokirova in the semifinal.

CWG gold medallist Sakshi Chaudhary (51kg)



Narender Berwal (third from left)

faces a tough opener against Paris Olympic bronze medallist Aira Villegas of the Philippines.

While Reigning Asian Championships gold medallist Preeti Pawar (54kg) has a first-round bye and is expected to face North Korea's Pang Chol-mi, the defending Asian Games champion, Olympic bronze medallist and two-time world champion.

Priya Ghanghas (60kg), also an Asian Championships gold medallist this year, opens against South

HIGHLIGHTS

» The Asian Games features six men's and five women's weight categories

» India had won four medals, including one silver and three bronze, in the previous edition

» Priya Ghanghas (60kg), also an Asian Championships gold medallist this year, opens against South Korea's Oh Yeonji

Korea's Oh Yeonji, a two-time world bronze medal-



Lovlina Borgohain

list, former Asian Games champion and three-time Asian champion.

World Championships bronze medallist Parveen Hooda (65kg), who was stripped of her medal from the previous edition after being suspended, starts against Tajikistan's Hozimova in the round of 16.

She could then face Uzbekistan's Navbakhor Khamidova, a silver medallist at both the World Championships organised by World Boxing and the IBA last year.

Among the men, Commonwealth Games silver medallist Jadumani Singh (55kg) opens against Nepal's Chandra Thapa and could face Tokyo Olympic silver medallist Carlo Paalam of the Philippines in the pre-quarterfinals.

Commonwealth Games gold medallist Sachin Siwach (60kg) has a first-round bye and could face World Championships bronze medallist Mohamad Abu Jajeh of Jordan in the pre-quarterfinals.

Shafali ton powers reigning champions India into Asian Games final

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Nissin, September 20

Reigning champions India stormed into the women's cricket T20I final at the Asian Games for a second successive edition on Sunday, confirming at least a silver medal and taking India's medal tally to four at the continental showpiece.

India already have won two silver medals in shooting and an assured bronze in mixed martial arts, while the women's cricket team added another confirmed medal by advancing to the gold-medal match with a crushing 114-run win over Bangladesh.

Shafali Verma peeled off her maiden T20I century, an unbeaten 100 off just 49 balls, to power India to a formidable 195 for four after opting to bat.

The Bangladesh chase then unravelled almost immediately as wickets fell at regular intervals, with the side eventually bowled out for just 81 in 15.4 overs. It was India's second-biggest win by runs against Bangladesh.

INDIA ALREADY HAVE WON TWO SILVER MEDALS IN SHOOTING AND AN ASSURED BRONZE IN MIXED MARTIAL ARTS

India will now face Sri Lanka in the gold-medal match on Tuesday, in a repeat of the last edition's final.

The two sides also clashed in the Women's T20 Asia Cup final last Sunday with India winning by 72 runs.

Sri Lanka defeated Pakistan by eight wickets in the first semifinal on Sunday.

Pakistan will now face Bangladesh for the bronze in the first match on Tuesday.

Nandani Sharma returned 4-0-25-3 and even came close to taking a hat-trick in the 11th over.

For Bangladesh, opener Dilara Akter with a 23-ball 27, studded with four fours and a six, was the only batter to provide any resistance as four of the top six batters fell for single-digit scores.

Injury has happened before, now let's work on comeback: Neeraj

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, September 20

India's star javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra termed his absence from the Asian Games unfortunate but said it was important to "accept" the setback and focus on making a quick comeback. The 28-year-old, who won India's first Olympic gold medal in athletics with his javelin triumph at Tokyo and followed it up with a silver in Paris, missed out on a chance to complete a hat-trick of Asian Games gold medals after suffering a ligament injury while training.

The injury came soon after Chopra produced a season-best throw of 88.05m at the Lausanne Diamond League, bringing his 2026 competitive season to an early end and ruling him out of the Asian Games and the Diamond League Final.

"It is definitely difficult. I wouldn't say it is easy," he said on the Khelo Bharat Podcast of the Sports Authority of India (SAI).

"It has become a little normal for me because this has happened quite a few times in my career. There



KEY POINTS

» The injury came soon after Chopra produced a season-best throw of 88.05m at the Lausanne Diamond League

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have been times when I was very well prepared and suddenly suffered an injury. "Even after winning many things, you still feel that if you had been able to use that time without the injury, perhaps even better things could have happened."

Chopra said the latest

injury was particularly frustrating because he felt he had finally returned to his best after recovering from an earlier setback.

"When I felt that I was finally back to being the old Neeraj again, with the same enthusiasm and consistency, I threw 88 metres. Then, just a day later, I got injured again during training. The first few minutes were very difficult for me. I couldn't process what was happening," he said.

"I pushed myself so much, mentally and physically. I had started training right from the beginning of the year. I hadn't really spent any time with my family. I had focused completely on training and competitions because it was a very busy year.

India set up QF against Japan in badminton

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Nagoya, September 20

India cruised past a lowly-ranked Kazakhstan 3-0 in the women's team event at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games here on Sunday, setting up a challenging quarterfinal against hosts Japan.

At the Ichinomiya City Municipal Gymnasium, Indian stalwart PV Sindhu, Unnati Hooda, and Tanvi Sharma completed a comfortable sweep without dropping a game. Sindhu, ranked 11th in the world, needed 24 minutes to beat Kamila Smagulova 21-7, 21-9 in the opening rubber. Kazakhstan's top woman shuttler Kamila's BWF world ranking is a lowly 426.

The world No. 24 Unnati then breezed past



India's PV Sindhu

Alissa Kuleshova (WR 866) 21-7, 21-10 in 22 minutes, before the world No. 26 Tanvi Sharma sealed the tie even quicker, defeating Diana Namenova (WR 1067) 21-5, 21-10.

But the road from

here is set to be a difficult affair for India, who had returned empty-handed from Hangzhou Asian Games 2023 after losing to Thailand in quarters.

Japan promises a far

SINDHU, RANKED 11TH IN THE WORLD, NEEDED 24 MINUTES TO BEAT KAMILA SMAGULOVA 21-7, 21-9 IN THE OPENING RUBBER. KAZAKHSTAN'S TOP WOMAN SHUTTLE KAMILA'S BWF WORLD RANKING IS A LOWLY 426

sterner test, with the hosts boasting three singles players inside the world's top 10 -- Akane Yamaguchi (No. 3), Tomoka Miyazaki (No. 7) and Nozomi Okuhara (No. 10).

Hence, the likely singles match-ups could see Sindhu face Yama-

guchi, while Unnati take on Miyazaki, and India's women's doubles pair of Treasa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand could face Japan's world No. 3 combination of Yuki Fukushima and Mayu Matsumoto.

India's top shuttler Sindhu is optimistic.

"We have a good team, and Japan also is a good, strong team, so it's going to be a tough one," said the Indian double Olympic medalist.

"Each match is important and it is going to be a good match, so hoping for the best, and I hope we win."

Making her fourth Asian Games appearance, the 31-year-old Sindhu who has a team bronze and individual silver, is also taking up a leadership role.

Hockey: India thrash Indonesia 13-1

Team India will next face Sri Lanka on Tuesday



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kakamigahara, Sept 20

Defending champions India produced a brilliant all-round performance led by striker Dilpreet Singh's four-goal haul to outplay unfancied Indonesia 13-1 in their opening Pool A match of the Asian Games here on Sunday.

All of Dilpreet's four strikes (18th, 19th, 37th, 49th) were field goals, while Shilanand Lakra (6th, 35th) and Sukhjeet

Singh (38th, 48th) scored a brace each for India.

The other goal-scorers were Abhishek (12th), Rajinder Singh (19th), Mandeep Singh (21st), skipper Harmanpreet Singh (28th), and Jugraj Singh (47th).

Indonesia's solitary goal was scored by Aulia Al Ardh in the 33rd minute.

India will next play Sri Lanka on Tuesday.

The Indians got off the blocks in the sixth minute through Lakra's rebound after skipper Harmanpre-

et's drag-flick was saved by Indonesia goalkeeper Alam Fajar. As expected, India controlled the possession and dominated most of the game. In the 12th minute, Abhishek doubled the lead from a rebound after the initial shot was saved by the Indonesian custodian.

Dilpreet made it 3-0 in the 18th minute, pushing in an assist from Abhishek.

A minute later, he scored his second goal of the match, guiding home a pass from Sukhejeet Singh

from the far post.

A few seconds later, Rajinder added his name to the score-sheet, turning in a rebound after excellent attacking play from Sukhjeet, and just two minutes later, Mandeep scored another field goal.

India continued to apply relentless pressure on the Indonesian defence, earning a penalty stroke in the 27th minute when Manpreet Singh was fouled inside the 'D' while trying to score on a rebound.

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA
PUBLIC WORKS DIVISION, NASHIK
E-Tender Notice No.13 for 2026-27 (Online)

Online E-Tenders in "B-1" Form for the following works invited by Executive Engineer, P.W.Division, Nashik Phone No. (0253/2583761-64, 2575324) for and on behalf of Governor of Maharashtra State From Capable of P.W.Deptt. Registered / Unregistered Contractor or International Contractor whose Sub company / branch in India and also complete terms and conditions mentioned in tender document.

Tender document download on our website <https://mahatenders.gov.in> Right of rejection of E-tender / cancellation of E-tender reserved by The Executive Engineer, P.W.Division, Nashik. *Conditional Tender will not be accepted.

Note :- Above mentioned E-Tender Notice including Total 4 (Four) (Costing upto Rs. 1500.00 Lacks) Works And details of mentioned E-Tender Notice available on below website.

1. www.mahapwd.gov.in

2. <https://mahatenders.gov.in>

Tender Document Sale Start and End Date Time	21.09.2026		to		28.09.2026	
	From	11:05		Upto	17:00	

* Blank E-Tender form Fees (Non refundable) and EMD amount will be accepted Online only.

* Post Qualification criteria condition included in tender document

* All eligible/ interested Contractors are required to be enrolled on portal <https://mahatenders.gov.in> before down loading tender documents and participate in e-tendering

* The information of E-Payment Gateway available on E-Tendering website <https://mahatenders.gov.in>

Please Note this to all Registered / Unregistered Contractors.

Executive Engineer
Public Works Division, Nashik

Dgipr/2026-27/2898

'EMILY IN PARIS' SEASON 6

Lily bids farewell to title character

Collins played the American marketing executive since the series premiered in 2020

Lily Collins bid adieu to Emily Cooper after wrapping filming the sixth and final season of Netflix's popular romantic comedy-drama 'Emily in Paris'.

Collins, who has played the American marketing executive since the series premiered in 2020, shared an emotional note on 'Instagram' after completing her final day on set.

"I'm speechless. It's impossible to find the words for what this journey has meant to me. For so many years, Emily has been a part of my life and through every season, she's continued to surprise me, inspire me and challenge me," she wrote.

The American actress thanked series creator Darren Star for creating the character and trusting her to bring Emily to life. "Thank you, Darren Star, for dreaming up this endlessly optimistic American girl in Paris who finds herself constantly outside of her comfort zone, learning to trust herself while leaning on others as she navigates her new life," Collins wrote.

She also thanked the show's crew, writers, directors and cast, describing her co-stars as family and saying they had helped make the fictional world of the series feel like home. "Saying goodbye feels completely



'I'M SPEECHLESS. IT'S IMPOSSIBLE TO FIND THE WORDS FOR WHAT THIS JOURNEY HAS MEANT TO ME,' SHE SAYS

surreal and bitter-sweet, but mostly, I feel so incredibly proud and grateful that I got to be her. And be part of something so joyful. This has forever changed me. Au revoir, Emily Cooper..." Collins wrote.

'Emily in Paris' follows Emily Cooper, an American marketing executive who moves to Paris for work and finds herself navigating a new culture, career, friendships and relationships. The series has been led by Collins alongside Philippine Leroy-Beaulieu as Sylvie, Ashley Park as Mindy Chen, Lucas Bravo as Gabriel, Samuel Arnold as Julien, Bruno Gouery as Luc, William Abadie as Antoine, Lucien Laviscount as Alfie and Paul Forman as Nicolas.

Across its run, the show has taken Emily beyond Paris, including Rome and Venice, while continuing to explore her professional and personal relationships. The sixth season will conclude the series and is scheduled to premiere on 'Netflix' on December 24. PTI

Deepika and Ranveer welcome second daughter

Several celebrities went on to congratulate the couple in the comments

Deepika Padukone and Ranveer Singh announced the birth of their second child, a baby girl.

Singh and Padukone, who have co-starred in films such as 'Ram-Leela', 'Bajirao Mastani' and '83', shared the news with a post on 'Instagram' on Saturday, which featured the poster with 'Welcome Baby Girl. 19.9.2026. Dua, Deepika and Ranveer' written on it.

Several celebrities went on to congratulate the couple in the comments. "Awww!! Congratulations, you guys!!! Dua has a baby sister," Kriti Sanon wrote. "Congratulations," said Kriti Kharbanda.

The couple tied the knot in November 2018 and welcomed their first daughter Dua on September 8, 2024. They announced the second pregnancy with a social media post that featured Dua holding a positive pregnancy test.

Singh recently appeared in 'Dhurandhar 2', which went on to earn over Rs 1000 crore at the global box office. He will next feature in 'Pralay'. The film is directed by Jay Mehta and is said to be a zombie and survival thriller.

Padukone will appear alongside Shah Rukh Khan in 'King'. The film is directed by



THE CELEBRITY COUPLE SHARED THE NEWS WITH A POST ON 'INSTAGRAM' ON SATURDAY

Siddharth Anand and also features Suhana Khan and others. PTI

'Put me in any role and I can do it'

Soni Razdan on moulding herself for every character

Veteran actress Soni Razdan doesn't put herself into preconceived boxes as a performer and approaches every role with the same enthusiasm.

The 69-year-old actress, who currently stars in the slice-of-life film 'Om Ka Hari', said she is confident she could adapt herself to a completely different setting, citing popular series 'Panchayat' as an example.

"As an actor, I approach every role with the same enthusiasm. Every role demands different things from me as an actor or from anybody as an actor. I approach it from that perspective. I think I just don't have these filters and these boxes don't exist in my own head," Razdan told PTI in an interview.

She added, "I feel if you cast me in 'Panchayat' tomorrow, I can fit in. You may not believe it, but I'll make you believe it because I can do it. You have to put me in that role. I will wear those sarees. And I will prove that I can do it."

In 'Om Ka Hari', Razdan stars alongside Raghuraj Yadav and Anshu

human Jha in a story about a father-son relationship. Directed by Harish Vyas, the film follows stubborn father Hari Prasad Sharma and his independent-minded son Om Prasad Sharma, with their conflicts taking them from Bhopal to Varanasi. She essays the role of Saroj, the wife of Hari and mother of Om, who finds herself mediating the strained relationship between the father and son.

Razdan credits her theatre background for her ability to mould herself into different characters. She began her career in theatre under veteran theatre director Satyadev Dubey and said the experience exposed her to a variety of roles. "I played all kinds of characters there. So, I think that's where my ability to mould myself as a character came from," said the actor, known for films such as '36 Chowringhee Lane', 'Saaransh', '1942: A Love Story', 'Patiala House', 'Raazi' and 'No One Killed Jessica'. PTI



Vijay Sethupathi confirms 'Maharaja 2'

Vijay Sethupathi confirmed that 'Maharaja 2' is in active development, revealing that director Nithilan Saminathan has already narrated the sequel's story to him and that he found it 'so beautiful'. In the same conversation, the actor also spoke about the Hollywood remake of the original, saying he told producer Sudhan Sundaram he would act in the American version for free if they gave him a role.



THE CONFIRMATION PUTS TO REST MONTHS OF SPECULATION ABOUT A POSSIBLE SEQUEL

"Nithilan is an excellent director. He has a great writing sense. He recently told me the story of 'Maharaja 2'. It was so beautiful. Working with him was superb," Vijay Sethupathi said during the audio launch of Batha, confirming that the sequel has progressed beyond initial discussions and that a full narrative is in place.

The confirmation puts to rest months of speculation about a possible sequel. The original, a neo-noir thriller about a barber who walks into a police station to report a stolen dustbin, was directed by Nithilan Saminathan. Made on a budget of approximately Rs 20 crore, the film collected Rs 190 crore worldwide and became one of the most profitable Tamil films of 2024.

Vijay also spoke candidly about Maharaja's success. While he said he always trusted the film, he admitted that he didn't anticipate how far it would even-

tually travel. "We never expected Maharaja to go this far. The movie was good, but some people didn't trust the film. I had that trust, but I didn't expect this," he said.

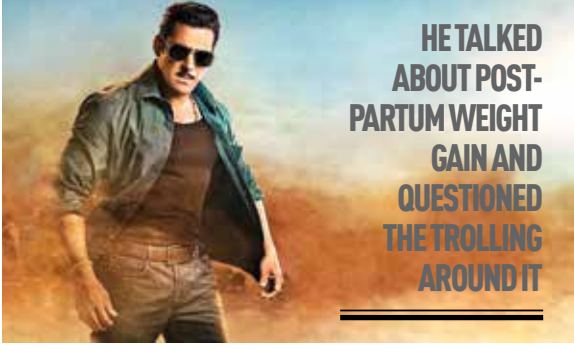
The film's international success also led to what Sethupathi described as one of the happiest moments of his career. Producer Sudhan Sundaram of 'Passion Studios' recently informed him that a Hollywood agency had acquired the remake rights to 'Maharaja'. "He recently called me and told me that he has sold the Hollywood rights of the film. I told him, 'I'll act in one movie for free. Get me a role in that Hollywood remake. I'll go to Hollywood!' It gives me such a great surprise and happiness. I've always had a big interest in working in Hollywood, but more than anything, I'm extremely happy that my movie is going to Hollywood," he said. AGENCIES

Salman Khan supports Katrina Kaif amid weight gain trolling

Bollywood superstar Salman Khan slammed trolls targeting Katrina Kaif over her weight gain after pregnancy.

Khan took off his shirt and wiped off the makeup during an episode of 'Bigg Boss Season 20' and addressed the trolls who have been mocking him for his changing appearance. Without naming anyone, the actor then went on to talk about postpartum weight gain and questioned the trolling around it. He also suggested that when the actress is ready to return to films, she will get fit, adding that everyone puts on weight after pregnancy.

"Why do you troll somebody who gets pregnant? Pregnant hone ke



HE TALKED ABOUT POSTPARTUM WEIGHT GAIN AND QUESTIONED THE TROLLING AROUND IT

baad everyone puts on weight... (everyone gains weight during pregnancy) Jab woh picturon mein wapas ajayegi toh woh fit ajayegi... (when she returns to films, she will be fit) she wants to spend time with her family," he said.

Kaif, who welcomed her son Vihaan in November 2025, recently appeared at the Ambani's

Ganesh Chaturthi celebrations in Mumbai alongside her husband, Vicky Kaushal. After the videos of the actor surfaced on the internet, a section of users went on to troll her. Several users have also shared her previous pictures from the films alongside her current look and compared them.

The actress hasn't commented on it. PTI

AGE-BASED CERTIFICATION OF FILMS

Ricky talks about content for kids & adults

Kej is part of the newly reconstituted Central Board of Film Certification

Grammy Award-winning musician Ricky Kej is part of the newly reconstituted Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC). He recently weighed in on the recently revised guidelines, which expand the age-based certification of films, following the amendments to the Cinematograph Act 2023 in May last year.

For Kej, the expanded age classifications could help reduce the need for cuts while giving parents greater clarity about what their children watch. "My priority, at least my personal priority on

HE HAS EXTENSIVELY MADE MUSIC PRIMARILY DESIGNED FOR CHILDREN

the board, will be to ensure that these classifications are applied accurately, so that parents are empowered to make informed choices and hopefully, we lessen the need to actually edit or cut content meant for mature audiences," argued Ricky, who has extensively made music primarily designed for children, which has allowed

him to 'care very deeply about the impact on young minds'.

However, Ricky pointed out that making cinema suitable for children doesn't have to come at the cost of sanitising even the films with an 'A' (Adults Only) certificate. "However, I do acknowledge that protecting children does not mean sanitising cinema for adults," he told NDTV. Recent trends have shown a surge in the success of 'A'-rated films, from Sandeep Reddy Vanga's 2023 family crime drama 'Animal' to Aditya Dhar's

more recent spy thriller franchise 'Dhurandhar'.

The Centre on Wednesday reconstituted the CBFC, bringing actors Preity Zinta, Pankaj Tripathi, Sunil Shetty, Pallavi Joshi and Prosenjit Chatterjee and filmmaker Priyadarshan, with others, onto its new 18-member board. Headed by chairperson and former Prasar Bharati CEO Shashi Shekhar Vempati, the reconstituted board has been given a three-year term or will continue until further orders, whichever is earlier. AGENCIES

